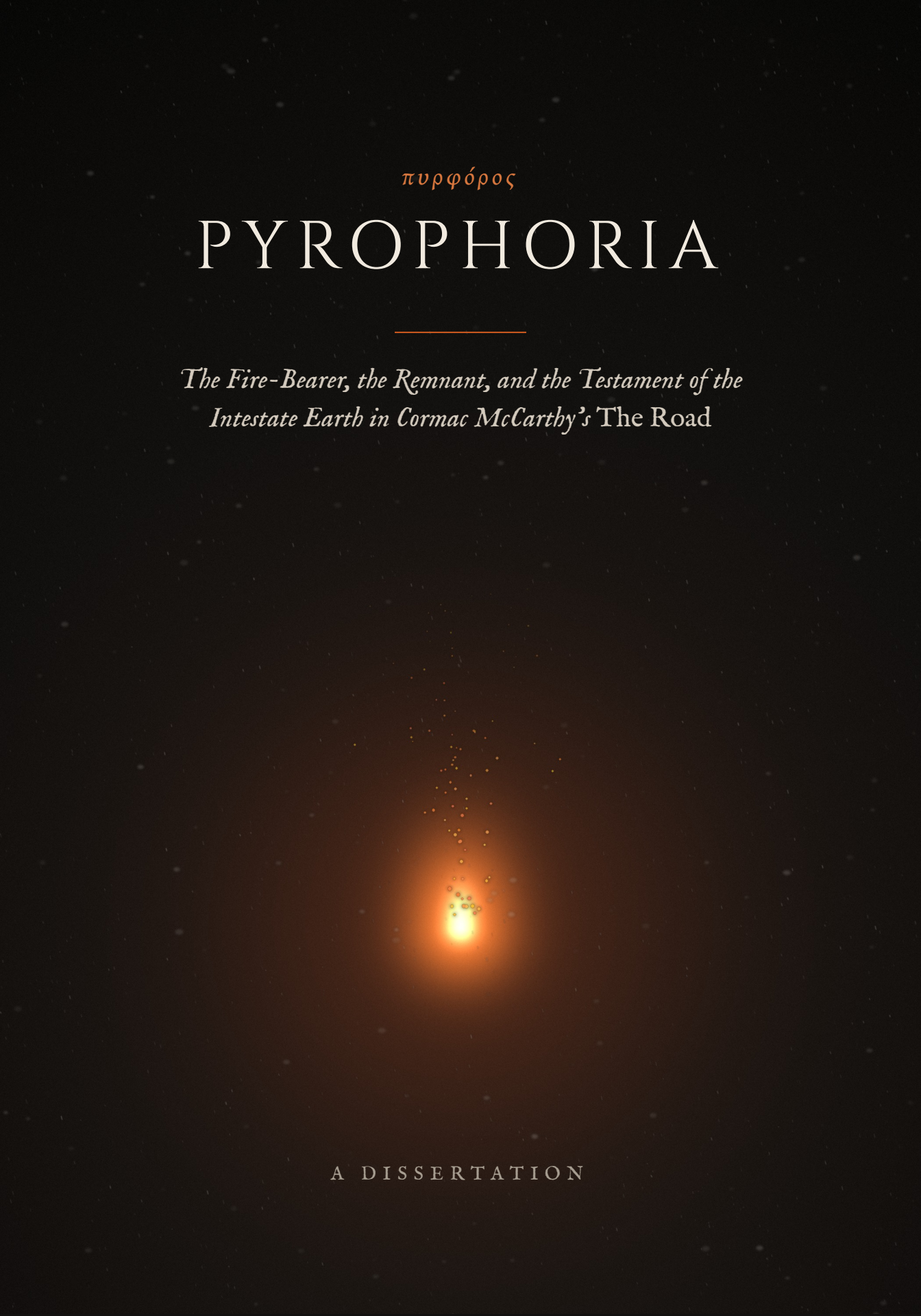
πυρφόρος

PYROPHORIA

The Fire-Bearer, the Remnant, and the Testament of the Intestate Earth in Cormac McCarthy's The Road



A DISSERTATION

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A DISSERTATION

October 2026

οὐδὲ πυρφόρος ἐλείφθη

Not even the fire-bearer was left.

GREEK PROVERB FOR A DEFEAT WITHOUT REMAINDER · CF. HERODOTUS 8.6

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) is neither a survival narrative in post-apocalyptic dress, nor a covert theodicy, nor an ecological allegory in any of the senses its reception has proposed, but the founding instance of a form it names *pyrophoric fiction*: a narrative in which the single value to survive the end of the world is a fire whose entire being consists in being carried. The term operates in two registers at once. In Greek military ritual the πυρφόρος was the sacrosanct bearer of altar-fire who marched with the Spartan army and was by convention spared, so that the proverb "not even the fire-bearer was left" (Hdt. 8.6.2) came to signify annihilation without remainder; in modern chemistry a pyrophoric substance ignites spontaneously on contact with air. McCarthy's fire inhabits both registers simultaneously. It is transmitted, from father to son, as Vesta's fire passes from Hector to Aeneas; and it is self-igniting, having been, as the dying father insists, inside the child all along. Pyrophoria thereby dissolves the nature–nurture antinomy that has governed debate about the boy's goodness into a third term, the *ignition-relation*: a good that is neither possessed nor instilled but catches only on contact with another.

The argument proceeds genealogically and comparatively. It reconstructs the figure of carried fire across Heraclitean and Stoic cosmology (the ever-living fire, *ekpyrosis*, the *pyr technikon*), Promethean, Pandoran and Vestal myth, Isaianic and Pauline remnant theology, Lurianic Kabbalah, Böhme's theosophy of the two fires, Hopkins's sacramental poetics, and McCarthy's own oeuvre, in which fire migrates from the epilogue of *Blood Meridian* through Sheriff Bell's closing dream in *No Country for Old Men* to the Manhattan Project father of *The Passenger*. It situates the novel among its philosophical interlocutors (Hobbes and Rousseau on the state of nature, Kierkegaard on the Akedah, Schopenhauer and Levinas on compassion, Nietzsche on the death of God, Jonas on responsibility and the God after Auschwitz, Arendt on natality, Benjamin on the end of storytelling, Heidegger on enframing, Derrida on the nuclear archive, Agamben on the remnant, Scheffler on the collective afterlife) and within a comparative corpus running from Hesiod, Virgil, Dante and Shakespeare through Byron, Mary Shelley and Melville to Bradbury, Shute, Miller, Beckett, Hoban, Saramago, Butler, Ishiguro and Atwood.

Its central claim is that *The Road* stages an apocalypse that is non-total by construction, because the fire-bearer survives, and that its double ending executes two testaments. The father's, spoken *in extremis* in the manner of a nuncupative will, bequeaths to the son a fire without content together with the gun that guards it, the same weapon once reserved for the son's death. The earth's, which in the novel's own word has died *intestate*, is written in its own hand as the vermiculate "maps of the world in its becoming" on the backs of vanished trout, and is bequeathed, through the coda's sudden second person, to the reader, the only figure who stands outside the catastrophe. The dissertation concludes by proposing pyrophoria as an ethics adequate to the Anthropocene: one that presupposes neither the survival of the world, nor the existence of God, nor the persistence of the archive, but only the act of carrying; and that answers the oldest Greek formula for absolute ending with the novel's last word, which is *mystery*.

Note on Citation and Abbreviations

Because *The Road* is unchaptered and its pagination differs between the Knopf hardcover and the Vintage paperback (both 2006), the novel is cited by episode ("the cellar," "the Ely episode," "the coda") rather than by page. In keeping with its subject, it is quoted with deliberate parsimony: its language is otherwise paraphrased, and its recurrent formulae ("carrying the fire," "the good guys," "okay") are treated as the motif-names they have become. Ancient and scriptural texts follow standard divisions: Hdt. = Herodotus, *Histories*; *Lac.* = Xenophon, *Constitution of the Lacedaemonians*; *Anab.* = Xenophon, *Anabasis*; *WD* = Hesiod, *Works and Days*; *Theog.* = Hesiod, *Theogony*; *PV* = Aeschylus, *Prometheus Bound*; *Od.* = Homer, *Odyssey*; *Aen.* = Virgil, *Aeneid*; *Ecl.* = Virgil, *Eclogues*; *Met.* = Ovid, *Metamorphoses*; *DRN* = Lucretius, *De rerum natura*; *BJ* = Josephus, *Bellum Judaicum*; *Inf.* and *Purg.* = Dante, *Inferno* and *Purgatorio*; DK = the Diels–Kranz numbering of the Presocratic fragments. Biblical citations follow the Authorized Version of 1611, the translation whose cadences McCarthy's prose most audibly inherits. All other works are cited author–date against the Works Cited.

INTRODUCTION

Not Even the Fire-Bearer

I.1 The Proverb and the Problem

Herodotus records that when the Persian commanders sighted the outnumbered Greek fleet at Artemisium, they declined to attack it head-on, fearing that the Greeks would slip away under cover of night; it was necessary, in their reckoning, that not even the fire-bearer should escape alive (Hdt. 8.6.2). The phrase was proverbial, and Xenophon explains its force. Before a Spartan army marched, the king sacrificed to Zeus Agetor, "the Leader," and a designated fire-bearer, the πυρφόρος, took fire from that altar and carried it at the head of the column to the frontier, where the next sacrifice would be kindled from it (*Lac.* 13.2–3). Because he bore the sacred continuity between the city's hearth and the army's rites in the field, the fire-bearer was by convention inviolable. To say that not even the fire-bearer was left was therefore to name a destruction that had passed beyond the last limit war itself respected: an annihilation without remainder, which consumed even the means by which sacrifice, and with it the relation to the gods and to the city, might have been resumed.

The modern literature of ending has repeatedly spoken the proverb in its own idiom, and Byron's "Darkness" (1816), composed in the volcanic "year without a summer" that followed the eruption of Tambora, is its purest instance. The sun is extinguished; men burn their dwellings for light; famine yields to mutual devouring; and the poem's last fire, scraped together from the embers of an altar by two surviving enemies, serves only to show them each other's faces, at whose mutual hideousness they shriek and die. Darkness, needing no further aid from them, becomes the universe. Byron's final fire is literally a fire-bearer's fire, kindled at an altar, and its one function is to complete the annihilation by revealing the face of the other as an object of horror. Nothing remains to carry anything.

Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* is constructed as the negation of the proverb and, more precisely, of Byron's poem, with which it shares an extinguished sun, a cannibal famine, an inaugural dream and a closing vigil over a corpse. Its world has ended in every respect in

which Byron's has, save one: the fire-bearer survives. A man and his son, both unnamed, walk south through an incinerated America toward a sea they have never seen, pushing a grocery cart that holds the inventory of a civilization, and they describe themselves, in a formula the boy will repeat until it hardens into a creed, as carrying the fire. The novel's problem is therefore not the one its genre appears to impose. It does not ask why the world ended; McCarthy pointedly declined to say (Jurgensen 2009). It does not ask whether its protagonists will survive; the father will not, and the son's survival is left in a suspension the coda declines to resolve. It asks what it means that anything is carried at all, when there is no altar from which the fire was taken and no frontier at which it might be rekindled. This dissertation contends that the answer to that question constitutes the novel's philosophy, and that this philosophy has not yet been named.

I.2 The State of the Question

The reception of *The Road* has been extraordinary in volume and, beneath its apparent variety, unusually uniform in its presuppositions. The novel won the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction in 2007; within months it had been chosen for Oprah Winfrey's televised book club, proposed by George Monbiot as possibly the most important environmental book ever written (Monbiot 2007), and read by Michael Chabon as a genre fiction of horror whose deepest subject is a parent's fear for a child (Chabon 2007). Academic criticism sorted itself along an axis already established in McCarthy studies: the long quarrel between readings that found in his work a metaphysical austerity verging on nihilism (Bell 1988) and readings that found, beneath the violence, moral parables of naming and knowing (Arnold 1999). Applied to *The Road*, the quarrel became theological. On one side stand redemptive readings: Allen Josephs's account of the novel as a quest for God (Josephs 2013), Lydia Cooper's apocalyptic grail romance (Cooper 2011), Thomas Schaub's "secular scripture" (Schaub 2009). On the other stand readings that find redemption foreclosed or suspended: Shelly Rambo's argument that the novel dwells "beyond redemption," in the Holy Saturday between death and any rising (Rambo 2008; cf. Rambo 2010), and Erik Wielenberg's demonstration that its morality is intelligible without theism (Wielenberg 2010). Gnostic readings of the earlier fiction (Daugherty 1992; Mundik 2016) have pressed the question whether McCarthy's creator is a demiurge; Ashley Kunsa has shown how the catastrophe is enacted at the level of the name (Kunsa 2009); and the essays collected by Julian Murphet and Mark Steven anatomize the novel's styles of extinction (Murphet and Steven 2012).

These readings disagree about almost everything except one assumption, so thoroughly shared that it has gone unremarked: that the fire must be decoded. It has been glossed as faith, goodness, hope, civilization, the divine spark, the human, language, love. Each gloss supplies the fire with a content, and each therefore inherits the impossible burden of

showing that this content survives a catastrophe the novel represents as having destroyed every content. The present study adopts the opposite procedure. It reads the fire not as a cipher for something else but as a figure whose meaning is exhausted by its mode of being, which is to be carried; and it argues that the novel's insistence on that mode, against every content one might assign the fire, is the most rigorous philosophical decision the book makes.

I.3 Terms: Pyrophoria and the Intestate Earth

The term proposed here, *pyrophoria*, holds two senses in one word, and the coincidence between them is the dissertation's founding observation. In its ritual sense, the pyrophore bears a fire that originates elsewhere and is destined for elsewhere: a medium of continuity between an altar left behind and a sacrifice to come. In its chemical sense, a pyrophoric substance requires no external spark; it ignites spontaneously on exposure to air. The first sense names transmission, the second spontaneity. The novel's fire possesses both properties, and the scenes in which it is named oscillate between them. The father teaches the formula; the boy, in their final conversation, asks whether the fire is real and where it is; the father answers that it is inside him, that it always has been, and that he can see it. The fire is at once a tradition, handed on in a ritual phrase, and an endowment, latent in the one who receives it and kindled only by exposure, in the boy's case exposure to the faces of strangers. This doubleness dissolves the antinomy, inherited from the quarrel between Hobbes and Rousseau and replayed in every discussion of the boy's goodness, between a morality instilled by nurture and a morality given by nature. The fire is neither. It is an *ignition-relation*: it catches only where one being comes into contact with another.

A third etymological strand completes the term. Greek φέρειν, "to carry," is the root not only of the fire-bearer's title but of μεταφορά, metaphor, which Aristotle defines as the *epiphora*, the carrying-over, of a name belonging to something else (*Poetics* 1457b). "Carrying the fire" is therefore, with a precision that can hardly be accidental in a writer as etymologically alert as McCarthy, the metaphor of metaphor: a figure whose vehicle is the act of figuration itself. In a novel that narrates the extinction of names, in which the words for colors, birds and things to eat follow their referents into oblivion, the one figure that survives is the figure of carrying-over. The fire is what language becomes when it has nothing left to designate and can only transmit.

The second term of the title is McCarthy's own. In the passage in which the father, waking in the dark, apprehends for an instant the world's final truth, the earth is said to circle *intestate*. The word is juridical and exact. To die intestate is to die without a will, leaving an estate that passes by default rules to heirs at law or, where none exist, escheats to the sovereign. It is also unmistakably theological: an intestate earth is an earth without a testament, Old or New. This dissertation argues that the novel's double ending supplies pre-

cisely what the word declares missing. The father's dying instructions constitute a nuncupative will, the oral testament that the law has historically permitted to soldiers in service and mariners at sea, persons *in extremis*. The coda, in which the earth inscribes its legacy on the backs of trout, constitutes a holographic will, written wholly in the testator's own hand. The legatee of the first is the boy. The legatee of the second is the reader.

I.4 Method and Wager

Methodologically, the study takes McCarthy at his word. He told Richard Woodward that books are made out of books (Woodward 1992), and *The Road*, a novel about the burning of every library, is among the most densely allusive he wrote. This is its archival paradox: a fiction that depicts the remainderless destruction of the archive can be composed only from the archive, and can be fully read only by someone who still possesses it. The reader who hears Hesiod in the child born into gray, Virgil in the child crowned with harmless flame, and Jeremiah in a land returned to formlessness is herself the remnant of the archive whose destruction she is reading about. The method is accordingly genealogical rather than source-critical. It does not claim that McCarthy consulted each text adduced; it claims that his figures are overdetermined nodes at which long traditions converge, and that the novel's meaning lies in what it subtracts from each tradition it inherits. Comparison with other speculative and philosophical fictions functions as the controlled variation of an experiment: each comparandum shows what the novel might have done, and thereby clarifies what it does.

The wager is that *The Road* founds a genre and an ethics at once. The genre is testamentary fiction, a narrative that executes the will of a dying world. The ethics is pyrophoria, an ethics that presupposes neither the world's survival nor God's existence nor the archive's persistence, but only the act of carrying.

I.5 Architecture

Chapter One reconstructs the cosmology of the ash-world, arguing that the novel's refusal to name its catastrophe converts apocalypse from an event into a condition: a Stoic *ekpyrosis* without the guarantee of *palingenesis*, calibrated to Schopenhauer's threshold of the worst world that can still continue. Chapter Two reads the closed sky as a meteorological theology, in which Nietzsche's metaphors for the death of God become weather and the father's conditional, which stakes the entire history of divine speech on a single child, displaces transcendence from the vertical axis to the horizontal. Chapter Three argues that the novel's cannibals are not atavists but the terminal form of modernity's conversion of life into stock, and that the boy's refusal of the demonic Eucharist preserves the last difference on which moral order depends. Chapter Four anatomizes the dyad as a dialectic of

pietas and *misericordia*, the Aenean ethics of the line and the Levinasian ethics of the stranger, mediated by an inverted Akedah and resolved in the bequest of a fire guarded by a gun. Chapter Five follows the decay of reference into the phatic liturgy of "okay," and beneath it into the image-thinking that McCarthy's late essay on the unconscious theorizes. Chapter Six assembles the genealogy of the carried fire and identifies the novel's innovation as the systematic subtraction of every support the fire has ever had. Chapter Seven reads the arrival at the sea, the father's death, the adoption and the coda as the execution of the two testaments; the Conclusion formalizes pyrophoria as an ethics for the after.

I

CHAPTER ONE

The Ash-World

Cosmology Without Measure

The world of The Road *has ended without an assignable cause, and this etiological blank is the novel's first philosophical decision: it converts apocalypse from an event, which would carry a meaning and a verdict, into a condition, which carries only the question of what is to be done.*

1.1 The Event That Will Not Be Named

The catastrophe is narrated once, in retrospect, with the economy of a police report: the clocks stopped at a particular minute after one o'clock; there was a protracted shearing of light; then a sequence of muffled concussions. Everything else is aftermath: an atmosphere thick with ash, a sun reduced to a smear, a cold deepening year by year, forests standing dead and toppling in the night, rivers without fish, a sky without birds, snow that falls gray. Readers have assigned the event to nuclear war, to asteroid impact, to supervolcanic eruption. McCarthy, asked directly, reported that geologists among his colleagues at the Santa Fe Institute thought it resembled a meteor strike, conceded that it might as well have been volcanic or nuclear, and declared the question unimportant beside the question of what one does (Jurgensen 2009). The novel's meteorology is consistent with each candidate. Crutzen and Birks's "twilight at noon" (1982) and the TTAPS model of nuclear winter (Turco et al. 1983) predict its soot-darkened skies, collapsing temperatures and photosynthetic failure; the Alvarez hypothesis attributes an analogous winter to the impact that ended the Cretaceous (Alvarez et al. 1980); and Tambora's ash produced the darkened summer that gave Byron his extinguished sun.

The refusal to choose is not evasion but form. An apocalypse with a cause is a judgment: the Flood answers violence, the fire of Sodom answers the violation of the stranger, the bowls of Revelation answer idolatry. A catastrophe without an assignable cause cannot be read as a verdict and so cannot be redeemed as a meaning; it can only be inhabited. Frank Kermode observed that the modern apocalypse had become immanent rather than imminent, a pervasive sense of crisis rather than a dated end (Kermode 1967), and James Berger that post-apocalyptic narrative concerns less the end than what survives it as symptom (Berger 1999). *The Road* radicalizes both observations. Its end is neither imminent nor immanent but simply past, and its "after" is the only time there is.

The indeterminacy carries a distinctly contemporary charge. Dipesh Chakrabarty has argued that anthropogenic climate change collapses the humanist distinction between natural history and human history (Chakrabarty 2009). The novel's undecidable event, which may equally have been a human act (a war) or a natural one (a bolide, a caldera), renders that collapse formal. The reader cannot determine whether the world was destroyed by nature or by history, and the novel's ethics must therefore be built without the consolation of either an innocent cosmos or a guilty humanity. This is what makes *The Road* Anthropocenic without ever mentioning climate: not its subject but its undecidability.

1.2 The Double 1:17

The one datum the novel supplies is the time on the stopped clocks: 1:17. Critics have connected it to Revelation 1:17, where the risen Christ lays his right hand on the prostrate seer and says, "Fear not; I am the first and the last." The connection suits a book that turns on a father's hand laid on a frightened child and on a theology of first and last things. But the numeral admits a second, symmetrical reading. Genesis 1:17 records that God set the lights "in the firmament of the heaven to give light upon the earth." The minute at which the novel's light fails is indexed to the verse in which, at the beginning of the canon, the luminaries were installed; and the same coordinates at the canon's end announce the one who is first and last. The time-stamp folds alpha onto omega. Creation's verse and apocalypse's verse share an address, and the catastrophe occurs at their intersection.

Read this way, *The Road* stages a de-creation, Genesis 1 run in reverse. Light dims (1:3); the greater and lesser lights are veiled (1:14–17); the herb yielding seed and the fruit tree die (1:11–12); the waters no longer bring forth moving creatures (1:20–21), so that the father finds no fish; the fowl vanish from the firmament; the beasts are gone; and the human creature to whom every green herb was given for meat (1:29) becomes, in the novel's darkest economy, meat. The Hebrew Bible had already imagined this reversal. Jeremiah's vision of the land under judgment returns the earth to the primordial *tohu wa-bohu*: "I beheld the earth, and, lo, it was without form, and void; and the heavens, and they had no

light ... I beheld, and, lo, there was no man, and all the birds of the heavens were fled" (Jer. 4:23–25). *The Road* is Jeremiah's verse extended into a world, with one decisive addition: within the formless and void there is still a man, and he is walking with a child.

1.3 The Senescence of the World

The ash-world is also the terminal case of one of the oldest topoi of Western cosmology, the *mundus senescens*, the world grown old. Lucretius closes the second book of *De rerum natura* with an aged ploughman shaking his head over fields exhausted by the labor of earlier generations, and with the doctrine that the world, like every compound, will decay (*DRN* 2.1150–1174); the poem itself ends not in consolation but in the plague of Athens, with the living brawling over pyres to burn their dead (*DRN* 6.1278–1286). Cyprian of Carthage, answering pagan charges that Christians had provoked the gods, retorted that the world itself had aged: the winter rains were failing, the summer sun warmed less, the fields bore less, and this was senescence rather than punishment (*Ad Demetrianum* 3–4). The topos has an Epicurean and a Christian variant, and the novel inherits both. With Lucretius it refuses to attribute the end to divine wrath; with Cyprian it senses that what is ending is a vitality, not merely a structure. But in *The Road* senescence is complete. The world is not old. It is dead, and still turning.

1.4 The Worst of All Possible Worlds

Against Leibniz's demonstration that the actual world is the best possible (Leibniz 1710), and Voltaire's mockery of it after Lisbon (Voltaire 1759), Schopenhauer advanced a counter-theorem whose rigor is often missed. The actual world, he argued, is the worst of all possible worlds, not in the sense that nothing worse can be imagined, but in the sense that a world even slightly worse could not continue to exist: its arrangements are calibrated to the bare threshold of persistence (Schopenhauer 1844, vol. 2, ch. 46). *The Road* is a fictional proof of this theorem. Its world sustains exactly as much life as can scrape on in tinned remnants and hoarded cellars, and no more; it contains nothing that regenerates; every scene measures a distance from the threshold, and the father's death is the moment at which, for him, it is crossed. The novel's one explicitly modal sentence, a query asking how what will never be differs from what never was, is the logic of the threshold-world stated as a riddle. In a world without a future, the possible collapses into the never-actual, and both the father's hopes for the boy and the boy's hopes for the good guys hang between the two.

Shakespeare's Edgar, leading his blinded father across the heath, supplies the corollary: "the worst is not / So long as we can say 'This is the worst'" (*King Lear* 4.1). As long as a voice remains to name the worst, the worst has not arrived, because the voice is itself a re-

mainder. The father of *The Road* can still say that this is the worst; the boy can still ask whether they are the good guys. The novel's ethics, I shall argue, is what keeps that voice in existence, and so inserts a difference into the collapse of the possible into the never.

1.5 The Iron Age, Completed

Hesiod's prophecy of the end of the iron race supplies the novel's sociology with uncanny exactness. Zeus will destroy this race, the poet says, when its children are born gray at the temples; when father is not of one mind with children, nor guest with host, nor comrade with comrade; when parents are dishonored and might makes right; and when Aidos and Nemesis, shame and righteous indignation, wrap themselves in white robes and depart to the immortals, leaving no defense against evil (*WD* 180–201). The boy of *The Road* is born after the catastrophe into a world uniformly gray, a child born gray in the most literal sense the iconography of ash allows. Hospitality, the bond between guest and host that Hesiod names as a criterion of civilization, has been annihilated so completely that strangers are not merely unsafe but edible.

Ovid's iron age adds three details: the guest is not safe from the host; the son peers before his time into his father's years; and piety lies vanquished, *victa iacet pietas*, as Astraea, last of the immortals, abandons the blood-soaked earth (*Met.* 1.144–150). The novel's cannibal bands enact the first. The second it inverts, for the boy dreads rather than desires his father's end. The third it denies outright. Of all the virtues, *pietas*, the dutiful love of father for son and son for father, is precisely the one the novel shows undefeated. Its world fulfills every Hesiodic and Ovidian criterion of the end except the dissolution of the bond between generations, and that exception is the novel.

1.6 Ekpyrosis Without Palingenesis

Behind the topoi of senescence and the iron age stands the most austere cosmology of ending that antiquity produced. Heraclitus declared that the cosmos was made by neither god nor man but was, is and will be an ever-living fire, kindling in measures and going out in measures (DK B30); that all things are an exchange for fire and fire for all things, as goods for gold (B90); and that the road up and the road down are one and the same (B60). The Stoics built on him a cosmology of cycles. At the end of each world-period the cosmos dissolves into fire, the *ekpyrosis*; in that conflagration nothing perishes that matters, because the fire is itself divine reason, a designing fire (*pyr technikon*) proceeding methodically toward generation and containing the seminal reasons (*logoi spermatikoi*) from which an identical world will be reborn in the *palingenesia* (Long and Sedley 1987, §46).

The Road takes over the Stoic catastrophe and deletes both of its guarantees. Its fire burned without measure: nothing suggests that the conflagration kindled and went out ac-

cording to a ratio, and the Heraclitean *logos* that governs the exchange of fire and things is precisely what the ash-world lacks. And its conflagration promises no regeneration: no seed remains in the burned soil, no designing fire waits to reconstitute the world. Yet the novel retains, in the strangest possible location, the Stoic doctrine of a residual fire. The only seminal reason to survive the conflagration is the one the father claims to see burning inside the boy. The *logos spermatikos* has migrated from the cosmos into a child; it is no longer a property of nature but of a relation. If the world is to be reborn, it will be not by cosmic necessity but by transmission. Heraclitus's road up and road down, one and the same, becomes McCarthy's road south, the same road walked toward death and toward whatever lies beyond it.

1.7 The Totalities the Novel Refuses

The comparative corpus confirms the specificity of this cosmology. Byron's "Darkness" anticipates the novel's imagery to a degree that can hardly be coincidental: "The bright sun was extinguish'd," and "the icy earth / Swung blind and blackening in the moonless air." McCarthy's father, in his hour of apprehension, sees the earth circling intestate while the sun's blind hounds run on through the dark; the blindness, the blackening and the circling are Byron's, and the legal adjective is McCarthy's addition. But Byron's poem fulfills the proverb. Its cannibalism is total, its last fire reveals the faces of enemies only to kill them with horror, and its final line installs Darkness as the universe. Mary Shelley's *The Last Man* (1826), the first secular novel of human extinction, ends with Lionel Verney setting out in a small boat to circle a deserted earth, writing a history addressed to no reader; its frame-tale recovers the prophecy from leaves scattered in the Sibyl's cave near Naples. Wells's Time Traveller stands on a terminal beach under a swollen red sun, the last life on earth a crawling thing at the margin of a lifeless sea (Wells 1895): an entropic eschatology, the heat death of a world grown cold. George R. Stewart's *Earth Abides* (1949) takes its title from Ecclesiastes 1:4, "one generation passeth away, and another generation cometh: but the earth abideth for ever," and imagines humanity's near-extinction as the earth's quiet resumption of itself.

Each of these works names a totality: Byron the totality of darkness, Shelley of solitude, Wells of entropy, Stewart of a nature that outlasts us. *The Road* refuses all four. Against Byron, its fire reveals the face of the other as an object not of horror but of obligation. Against Shelley, its last human is not alone, because its last human is two. Against Wells, its terminal beach is not the end of the story but the place where an adoption occurs. Against Stewart, it inverts Ecclesiastes itself: the earth does not abide while a generation passes; the earth passes, intestate, and a generation, reduced to one father and one son, abides long enough to hand something on.

II

CHAPTER TWO

Meteorological Theology

The Closed Sky and the Horizontal Absolute

The Road *does not decide whether God exists; it closes the sky, literally, and thereby forces transcendence to migrate from the vertical axis of heaven to the horizontal axis of a relation.*

2.1 Nietzsche's Metaphors Made Weather

In section 125 of *The Gay Science* (1882), the madman who runs into the marketplace with a lantern on a bright morning to announce that God is dead describes the event in a cascade of cosmological images. Who gave us the sponge to wipe away the entire horizon? What were we doing when we unchained this earth from its sun? Are we not straying as through an infinite nothing? Has it not become colder? Is not night continually closing in? Must not lanterns be lit in the morning? Nietzsche's figures are metaphors for a metaphysical event: the death of God is said to be like the loss of the sun. *The Road* reverses the vector of the figure. Its sun is in fact obscured, its horizon in fact wiped to an undifferentiated gray, its cold in fact deepening, its night all but continuous, and its travelers must in fact carry fire at noon. The metaphysical event is no longer rendered by cosmological images; a cosmological event renders the metaphysical one. I call this reversal *meteorological theology*: the death of God has become the weather, and theology is conducted under a sky that has been closed like a lid.

The reversal has a polemical edge. Nietzsche's madman concludes that to be worthy of the deed we must ourselves become gods. In the ash-world, the only figures who have assumed sovereignty over life and death, who have passed beyond good and evil and revalued the human body as a resource, are the cannibals. The novel submits the Nietzschean

exit to an empirical test and reports the result: in a world without God, the self-made god is the one who keeps human beings in a cellar. Ely, the old wanderer, states the counter-theorem in a sentence: where human beings cannot live, gods fare no better. The novel's theology begins from that dependence.

2.2 Job Without the Whirlwind

The father's relation to God is not denial but address, and address of the most violent kind. Alone in the woods, he lifts his face and whispers to the absent deity, asking whether he is there, whether he will be seen at the last, whether God has a neck by which he might be throttled, a heart, a soul; he damns him; and he calls on him again. The scene belongs to the oldest tradition of protest prayer. Job, sitting among the ashes (Job 2:8), declares that God has cast him into the mire so that he is become like dust and ashes (30:19), and demands an audience. Job receives one: the voice from the whirlwind (38–41), followed by restoration (42). *The Road* is the Book of Job with both endings excised. No theophany answers the father, and nothing is restored to him; he dies on the coast with his son beside him.

Dostoevsky is the second interlocutor. In "Rebellion" (*The Brothers Karamazov*, Book V, ch. 4), Ivan assembles a dossier of atrocities against children, the infant caught on bayonets, the girl locked in a freezing privy, the serf boy torn apart by hounds, and on its basis respectfully returns his ticket to a harmony purchased with a tortured child's tears. *The Road* contains its own dossier, more terrible because encountered rather than reported: the captives in the cellar, the infant blackening on a spit at an abandoned camp, the boy spattered with a stranger's brains and washed in a river by a father who tells himself that this is his job. The father does not return his ticket, because he cannot: the ticket is the boy. Camus's *The Plague* (1947) stages the same crisis in the death of the magistrate Othon's son, which drives the Jesuit Paneloux to his second sermon, where the believer must either believe everything or deny everything, and drives Rieux to refuse, until his dying day, to love a scheme of things in which children are put to torture. *The Road* holds both responses in a single man: Rieux's refusal in his curses, Paneloux's all-or-nothing in his conditional.

Pascal named the deity of this situation the hidden God, after Isaiah's "Verily thou art a God that hidest thyself" (Isa. 45:15), and confessed the terror of the eternal silence of infinite spaces (*Pensées* §201 Lafuma). In the ash-world even that terror is foreclosed. The spaces are no longer infinite; they end a few hundred feet overhead in a ceiling of ash. The silence is no longer cosmic but local and immediate: the silence of a sky that has become a wall.

2.3 The Father's Conditional

The father's most consequential theological statement is not a curse but a conditional. Early in the novel he reflects that the one thing he knows is that the child is his warrant, and adds that if the boy is not the word of God, then God never spoke. The sentence has the form of a material conditional, $\neg W \rightarrow \neg S$, whose contrapositive, $S \rightarrow W$, is more startling still: if God has ever spoken, the boy is that speech. The conditional evacuates the entire archive of revelation (Sinai, the prophets, the Gospels, every word ever attributed to God) and relocates it in a single, present, perishable body. It is radically anti-archival: revelation is here, in this child, or nowhere and never. It is also a wager in Pascal's strict sense. The father cannot verify the antecedent. What he can do is keep the boy alive, and thereby keep the conditional's consequent from being forced; so long as the child lives, it remains possible that God spoke. Under these conditions theology becomes indistinguishable from care. To feed the boy, warm him and keep the pistol loaded for him is to keep open the question of revelation.

The Johannine resonance is plain: "In the beginning was the Word … In him was life; and the life was the light of men. And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not" (John 1:1–5). The Greek verb, *katelaben*, means both "understood" and "overcame," and the novel holds both senses: the darkness neither comprehends the boy's goodness nor extinguishes it. The father's word for the boy, *warrant*, belongs to the same juridical register as *intestate*. A warrant is an instrument that authorizes an act, and the boy authorizes the father's continuance, his violence, his refusal of his wife's counsel. Elsewhere, watching the boy by firelight, the father perceives him as a golden vessel fit to house a god; the image is Eucharistic, and it prepares the opposition between two kinds of eating that Chapter Three examines. What must be registered here is the novel's juridical theology. Its sacred terms are legal ones: the earth dies without a will, the child is a warrant, and the father, as he tells the boy, was appointed by God to care for him. God figures as an absent sovereign who has left no testament, and the father acts under a warrant that is a child.

2.4 Ely: The Prophet of Absence

The old man who calls himself Ely, and later admits that this is not his name, is the novel's prophet, and his prophecy is negative. The name recalls both Eli, priest of Shiloh, and Elijah, who was fed in the wilderness by ravens and then by the widow of Zarephath, whose son he raised from the dead (1 Kings 17). McCarthy's Elijah is fed not by ravens but by a boy who insists, over his father's resistance, on sharing their food; and he raises no one. His doctrine is that there is no God and that he and those like him are God's prophets, a sentence that compresses the whole tradition of negative theology into a paradox: the prophet's message is the absence of the one who sends him. He holds that things will be

better when everyone is gone, that death itself will then have its days numbered, and that a child on the road is a burden he would not wish to carry.

Ely belongs to the anti-natalist tradition whose most rigorous formulation appeared in the same year as the novel: David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been* (Benatar 2006), which argues from an asymmetry between the badness of present pain and the non-badness of absent pleasure that coming into existence is always a harm. The wife, as Chapter Four shows, holds a version of the same view, and so does the suicidal professor White in *The Sunset Limited*, McCarthy's dialogue of that same year. Against all three the novel offers no counter-argument. It offers a child who gives an old man a tin of fruit. Ely's remark about the dependence of gods on human habitation admits two readings. The Feuerbachian reading takes it as confirmation that God was always a projection of the human essence (Feuerbach 1841), so that the gods die with their projectors. The Jonasian reading, developed below, takes it as the description of a God who has made himself dependent on the world. The novel does not choose between them; it lets the boy act as though the second were true.

2.5 Tzimtzum, Decreation and the God After Auschwitz

The theology implied by the novel's practice has been articulated most precisely in Jewish and Christian thought shaped by the twentieth century's catastrophes. In the Lurianic Kabbalah reconstructed by Gershom Scholem, creation begins with *tzimtzum*, God's contraction of himself to make room for what is not God; the vessels formed to receive the divine light shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*); sparks of that light fall and are trapped among the husks of the broken world; and human action, *tikkun*, consists in gathering and raising them (Scholem 1941). The ash-world is a world after the breaking of the vessels. Its institutions, cities and archives have shattered; its sparks, if any remain, survive in scattered persons; and the boy, imaged by his father as a vessel fit for a god and said by him to carry a fire within, is at once a surviving vessel and a spark. To carry the fire is the novel's word for *tikkun*.

Simone Weil radicalized the doctrine of withdrawal into a mystical ethics. God, she wrote, can be present in creation only in the form of absence; the creature's highest act is to consent to its own decreation; and attention, at its highest degree, is the same thing as prayer (Weil 1952). The father's ceaseless vigilance over the sleeping boy, the touch in the dark, the listening for each breath, is prayer in exactly this sense: an attention so total that it has no other object. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, writing from Tegel prison in July 1944, proposed that mature faith must live in the world *etsi deus non daretur*, as though God were not given, borrowing the phrase in which Grotius had grounded natural law (Grotius 1625, Prolegomena §11), and that before God and with God we live without God (Bonhoeffer 2010). The boy's goodness is this religionless holiness exactly. He does not do good because

God commands it; he does good as though God were not given, and the father's conditional suggests that in doing so he may be God's only remaining word.

The fullest articulation is Hans Jonas's. In "The Concept of God after Auschwitz" (Jonas 1987), Jonas proposed a myth in which God, in creating, renounced his own being and gave himself over to the becoming of the world. Such a God is suffering, becoming and caring, but not omnipotent; he did not intervene at Auschwitz not because he would not but because he could not; and having given himself whole to the world, he has nothing further to give, so that it is now for human beings to give to him. Two features of the novel acquire their full sense under this myth. The first is Ely's dependence thesis, which Jonas's God would accept. The second is the direction of the boy's giving. He gives to Ely, to the thief, to the absent owners of a bunker's stores; in every case the gift moves horizontally toward a human being rather than vertically toward God. In Jonas's myth there is no other direction in which a gift to God could now travel. Alfred North Whitehead's process theology, which calls God "the great companion—the fellow-sufferer who understands" (Whitehead 1929, part V), supplies the final term. When, in the last pages, the boy finds it easier to speak to his dead father than to God, he is not abandoning theology. He is addressing the only form the divine could still take for him: a companion in suffering who understands.

2.6 The Remnant: Shear-jashub and the Time That Remains

The prophet Isaiah gave his son a name that was a prophecy, Shear-jashub, "a remnant shall return" (Isa. 7:3; cf. 10:21–22), and declared that he and the children the Lord had given him were "for signs and for wonders in Israel" (8:18). In the vision of his calling, Isaiah is told that the cities will be wasted without inhabitant and the land made utterly desolate, that even the tenth that remains shall be burned again, and yet that, as a terebinth or an oak keeps its stump when felled, "so the holy seed shall be the substance thereof" (6:11–13). *The Road* is set in a land of felled and burned trees, and its father too regards his son as a sign. The boy is Shear-jashub: a child whose existence is the prophecy that something remains.

Paul transforms the remnant from a quantity into a structure: "at this present time also there is a remnant according to the election of grace" (Rom. 11:5). Giorgio Agamben's commentary argues that the Pauline remnant is neither the whole nor a part of the whole, but the impossibility of the part and the whole coinciding with themselves or with one another, and that messianic time is the time that time takes to come to an end (Agamben 2005). This is the time of *The Road*: not the end of time but the time the end takes, a remainder that is not a surviving fragment of the old world (the dyad is not a portion of humanity in any statistical sense) but the very non-coincidence of the world with its own ending. Walter Benjamin's second thesis on the concept of history attributes to every generation a weak messianic power on which the past has a claim (Benjamin 1968). The boy

has precisely such a power, and only such a power: weak, unarmed, dependent, but bearing the claim of everything that has been destroyed. In *The Road* the remnant is not who survives. It is what is carried.

2.7 Horizontal Transcendence

The chapter's result can be stated as a proposition. Under a closed sky, transcendence does not disappear; it changes axis. The vertical relation, between earth and heaven, creature and creator, is obstructed by ash. The horizontal relation, between father and son and, through the son, between the dyad and every stranger it meets, becomes the only place where something exceeding the given can occur. The father stakes divine speech on the child; the child spends that stake on strangers. What the novel calls the fire is the name of this transfer of the absolute from the sky to the road.

III

CHAPTER THREE

The Anthropophagic Polis

Nature, Stock and the Demonic Eucharist

The cannibals of The Road *are not a regression to the state of nature but the terminal form of modernity's conversion of life into stock, and the boy's refusal to eat human flesh preserves the last distinction on which any moral order depends.*

3.1 Hobbes's Experiment, Run to Completion

Hobbes describes the natural condition of mankind as a war of every man against every man, in which there is no place for industry, no culture of the earth, no navigation, no account of time, no arts, no letters, no society, and, worst of all, continual fear and danger of violent death, so that the life of man is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (*Leviathan*, ch. 13). He concedes that such a condition was never generally so over all the world, and finds its approximations in civil war and in the posture of sovereigns. *The Road* runs Hobbes's counterfactual to completion on a continental scale. Every item on his list of absences appears in its world as an absence: no industry, no agriculture, no navigation, no reckoning of time (the father has long since stopped keeping a calendar), no arts, no letters, no society. The father's practical reason is impeccably Hobbesian. He trusts no one, travels armed, hides at the first sound of an engine, and kills preemptively when the boy is seized.

Hobbes's account of paternal dominion is less often remembered and more illuminating. In chapter 20 of *Leviathan* he argues that dominion by generation arises not from begetting but from the child's consent, express or presumed, given in return for preservation: whoever preserves the infant may be presumed to have its consent to his authority. The dyad is a Leviathan in miniature, a commonwealth of two in which the father's sover-

eignty is grounded in preservation and ratified by the boy's repeated "okay," a word that functions, as Chapter Five argues, as a covenant renewed daily. But the miniature differs from its model in one respect that subverts Hobbes's whole construction. In *Leviathan* the subject may not contest the sovereign's judgment of what conduces to peace. In *The Road* the subject does little else. The boy disputes the father's refusal to help a man burned by lightning, his refusal to search for a small boy glimpsed in a ruined town, his reluctance to feed Ely, his punishment of the thief. The covenant of the dyad is not a covenant of fear but of mutual correction, and at the novel's moral climax it is the sovereign who yields.

3.2 Rousseau's Pity and Golding's Island

Rousseau objected that Hobbes had imported into the state of nature the passions of a corrupted society, and had overlooked the one principle anterior to reason that tempers self-love: *pitié*, the natural repugnance at seeing any sentient being, and especially one's fellow, perish or suffer (Rousseau 1755, part 1). The boy of *The Road* is the closest thing modern fiction has produced to an experimental test of Rousseau's thesis. Born after the catastrophe, he has never known society, law, commerce or church; he has known only the state of nature and his father. And he displays, from first page to last, a pity so insistent that it repeatedly endangers his survival. Against Hobbes, the novel's datum is that a child raised in the war of all against all may turn out to be at war with no one.

The datum is complicated by the father's tutelage. Rousseau's *Émile* (1762) imagines a tutor who educates by withholding, protecting the child's nature from society's deformations. The father educates by stories, old stories of courage and justice that the boy will eventually judge untrue. The fire is therefore not a pure Rousseauvian endowment: it is the boy's pity ignited, and then exceeded, by the father's narratives. Here the pyrophoric structure first becomes visible. The fire is transmitted, through the stories, and self-igniting, in the boy's spontaneous response to faces the stories never described.

William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) is the novel's antithesis among modern state-of-nature fictions. Golding's marooned schoolboys revert under Jack's leadership to hunting, ritual and murder; their signal fire, emblem of civilization and of the hope of rescue, is neglected by the hunters and finally replaced by the conflagration with which they hunt Ralph across the island; and the rescue that arrives is summoned, with savage irony, by the destructive fire and delivered by a naval officer engaged in a war of his own. Golding locates the darkness in the child's heart. McCarthy locates the fire there. And where Golding's fires summon a rescuer, the flare that McCarthy's father fires over a dead sea summons no one.

3.3 Stock: Cannibalism as Terminal Modernity

The cellar is the novel's center of horror and its most precise social analysis. In the basement of an old plantation house, its door locked, the father and son discover naked men and women held captive by the band that occupies the house and kept alive as a living larder: their captors have been cutting off their limbs and eating them while keeping the captives alive. The horror lies less in the eating than in the keeping. The captives are inventory. What the cellar enacts is not a return to savagery but the logic of the stockpile, a rational economy of preservation applied to human beings.

Heidegger's analysis of modern technology supplies the terms. The essence of technology, he argued, is *Gestell*, enframing: a mode of revealing that challenges everything forth into availability as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, on call for further ordering; and the extreme danger is that the human being, who orders the standing-reserve, comes to be taken as standing-reserve himself (Heidegger 1977). The cellar is *Gestell* in its terminal form. Human beings are revealed solely as stored energy, held on call for consumption. Marx had already supplied the metaphor the scene literalizes: capital is dead labor that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labor (Marx 1887, ch. 10). The cannibal bands of *The Road*, with their trucks, their marching columns, their slaves in harness, their captive women, some of them pregnant, and the boys in dog collars whom the novel calls catamites, boys kept for sexual use, are not tribes but economies. They are the last enterprises on earth, and their product is the human body, eaten as food and used as sexual property. The novel leaves the purpose of the pregnant captives unstated; the spitted newborn discussed below invites the inference that pregnancy itself has become a food supply.

Giorgio Agamben's account of the camp as the hidden paradigm of modern political space, the place where human beings are reduced to bare life, *zoē* stripped of *bios*, completes the analysis (Agamben 1998). The cellar is a camp in Agamben's sense, and its captives are *homines sacri*, killable without sacrifice. In *The Open*, Agamben describes an anthropological machine by which Western thought produces the human by separating it from the animal (Agamben 2004). The cellar runs the machine in reverse; it produces livestock out of human beings. The comparative corpus confirms that this is the logic of a modernity rather than a primitivism. Wells's Morlocks, descendants of an industrial proletariat, keep and eat the Eloi in a class cannibalism that is the endpoint of capitalist division (Wells 1895). Swift's *A Modest Proposal* (1729) offers the infants of the Irish poor as a commodity to be raised and sold for the tables of the rich, in a prose of impeccable economic reasonableness. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) relocates the cellar to an English boarding school, where cloned children are raised, with art classes and tenderness, as organ stock. The spitted infant and the cellar of *The Road* are Swift's proposal and Ishiguro's Hailsham with every euphemism burned away.

3.4 The Demonic Eucharist

Northrop Frye's archetypal theory distinguishes the apocalyptic imagery of desire fulfilled from its demonic parody, and finds the demonic counterpart of the communion symbol in the cannibal feast (Frye 1957, third essay). *The Road* is organized around this opposition with schematic clarity. On one side stand the scenes of demonic eating: the cellar; a newborn on a spit at a campfire abandoned by a band of men traveling with a pregnant woman, who had passed the father and son shortly before; by every indication the child was hers, killed and roasted by the group she traveled with, though the novel shows neither who killed it nor whether she took part; the bones of roadside camps. On the other stand scenes of a eucharist without consecration: the can of Coca-Cola the father finds in a wrecked vending machine and gives to a boy who has never tasted one; the buried shelter whose shelves of tinned food constitute a cornucopia, a paradise in the earth; and above all the grace the boy pronounces there. He addresses it not to God but to the absent people who stored the food. He thanks them; he tells them that if they were present the travelers would not eat it, however hungry; he regrets that they did not get to eat it themselves; he hopes that they are safe in heaven with God. The grace is horizontal, addressed to human benefactors; conditional, renouncing the food in the presence of its owners; and vicarious, mourning the deprivation of others at the moment of one's own relief. It is the precise inverse of the cellar. Where the cannibals convert persons into food, the boy converts food back into a relation between persons.

The biblical tradition knows cannibalism as the sign of covenant curse. Deuteronomy's catalogue of the curses that follow disobedience reads like an inventory of the ash-world: "thy heaven that is over thy head shall be brass, and the earth that is under thee shall be iron. The LORD shall make the rain of thy land powder and dust: from heaven shall it come down upon thee, until thou be destroyed" (Deut. 28:23–24); in the siege they shall eat the flesh of their sons and daughters (28:53); and they shall find no ease, saying in the morning, would God it were even, and at even, would God it were morning (28:65–67). Second Kings records two mothers in besieged Samaria who agreed to eat their sons on successive days (2 Kings 6:28–29); Lamentations, the pitiful women whose own hands have sodden their children (Lam. 4:10); and Josephus, in the most notorious episode of the Roman siege of Jerusalem, a woman named Mary who roasted her infant son, ate half, and offered the rest to the rebels who broke in to seize her food (*BJ* 6.201–213). The spitted infant of *The Road* stands at the end of this genealogy, and exactly so: every case in it is a parent eating his or her own child, and the novel's newborn was, by every indication, the child of the woman whose band roasted it. Its world is the Deuteronomic curse executed without a covenant to have broken: brass sky, iron earth, rain of dust, children eaten, and no sin to explain it.

Homer had already identified anthropophagy as the antithesis of hospitality. Polyphemus, who devours Odysseus's men two at a time in his cave, is impious precisely because he disregards Zeus Xenios, protector of strangers (*Od.* 9). The cellar is the Cyclops's cave, and the flight from the house is an Odyssean escape. The deeper antecedent is Dante's Ugolino, imprisoned in a tower with his sons and grandsons and left to starve. In the *Inferno* the starving boys offer their father their own flesh, saying it would grieve them less if he ate them, since he clothed them in this wretched flesh and may strip it off (*Inf.* 33.61–63); and Ugolino's narrative ends on the most debated line of the canticle, that thereafter fasting had more power than grief (33.75). *The Road* answers the Ugolino crux in advance. Early in the novel the boy asks whether they would ever eat anybody, even if they were starving, and the father tells him they would not. The offer of the sons' flesh, which in Dante is the culmination of filial love, is in McCarthy foreclosed by a question. The difference between Ugolino and the man is that the son asks before the hunger can ask for him.

3.5 Girard: The Last Difference

René Girard's theory of the sacrificial crisis explains why the distinction between the good guys and the bad guys, which critics have often found naïve, is the most important structure in the book. For Girard, social order rests on differences; when they collapse, mimetic rivalry generalizes into a violence of all against all in which antagonists become monstrous doubles of one another, until the community discharges its violence upon a scapegoat (Girard 1977). The ash-world is a world of undifferentiation: the distinctions of class, property, law, nation and creed have burned away, and every survivor is a potential enemy and a potential meal. In such a world the dyad's binary is the last surviving difference, and maintaining it is the whole of the moral task. The novel registers continually that the difference is unstable. The father's violence resembles that of the men he fears; the road-rat he shoots is, like him, an armed man with a stake in a child; and when he strips the thief on the beach and leaves him naked, he has become, in the boy's eyes, a bad guy. The boy's repeated question, whether they are still the good guys, is the anxious monitoring of a difference always about to collapse into doubling.

The father's memory of men burning a winter den of snakes supplies the novel's own theory of this danger. In his recollection, men poured fuel on serpents knotted together in hibernation and set them alight; the snakes, being mute, writhed without screaming, and the men watched in a matching silence and went home to their suppers; and the narration suggests that what the men could remedy was not evil but only their image of it. The scene is a precise Girardian parable: violence directed at an image of evil, discharged on mute victims, followed by silence. The father's memory knows what his practice risks, and it is the boy who prevents the risk from being realized. In *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* Girard

argues that the Gospels' anthropological revelation consists in exposing the innocence of the victim and thereby disabling the scapegoat mechanism (Girard 2001). The boy performs this revelation without the Gospels. He sees the thief, the starving old man and the burned stranger not as figures of evil but as victims, and his weeping restores the difference between the good guys and the rest at the very moment his father is about to dissolve it.

IV

CHAPTER FOUR

Pietas and Misericordia

The Dyad and Its Two Ethics

The dyad of father and son is a dialectic between two ethics, the father's pietas, *the protective love of one's own, and the boy's* misericordia, *compassionate exposure to the stranger; neither suffices alone, and the novel resolves them in the bequest of a fire guarded by a gun.*

4.1 The Dyad as World

The novel describes father and son as each the whole of the other's world, and the description is meant literally. The Heideggerian structure of being-in-the-world (Heidegger 1927) presupposes a world, a referential totality of equipment, practices and others within which existence finds its possibilities. When that totality burns away, being-in-the-world contracts into being-in-the-dyad. Peter Sloterdijk's spherology describes the primordial human space as a dyadic "bubble," the shared interior out of which all larger worlds are later built (Sloterdijk 2011). *The Road* reverses the developmental sequence: the macrosphere collapses, and the microsphere, now formed by a father and a son, is all that remains.

Hans Jonas supplies the ethical correlate. In *The Imperative of Responsibility* he argues that the archetype of all responsibility is the newborn, whose mere breathing addresses an irrefutable ought to the world around it, so that one has only to look in order to know (Jonas 1984, ch. 4). The father's nightly vigilance, waking in the dark to touch the sleeping child and listen for his breath, enacts Jonas's archetype with a literalness Jonas could only gesture toward. But Jonas extends parental responsibility into a new imperative for the

technological age: act so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth. *The Road* compresses the object of that imperative into one child. The whole future of humanity, so far as the father can know, is the boy; the archetype and its universalization have become the same person.

4.2 Pius Aeneas

The father's ethics has a precise classical name. *Pietas*, the virtue that defines Virgil's Aeneas, is duty toward gods, country and kin, and its emblem is the image with which Aeneas leaves burning Troy: his father Anchises on his shoulders, holding the household gods; his small son Iulus clasping his right hand and following, as Virgil says, *non passibus aequis*, with unequal steps (*Aen.* 2.707–724). No image in Western literature better describes the visual signature of *The Road*: a man and a boy walking hand in hand down a road, the boy's steps shorter than the father's, the father at times carrying the boy on his back across a stream. Milton's final lines, in which Adam and Eve, "hand in hand with wandering steps and slow," take their solitary way out of Eden (*Paradise Lost* 12.646–649), supply the same figure at the threshold of the fallen world; McCarthy's pair walk the road that leads away from its last ruins. Aeneas's journey is also a flight with fire, as Chapter Six will show; what concerns us here is its ethics. *Pietas* is particular. It binds one to one's own: one's father, son, gods and city. It authorizes violence on their behalf, and Aeneas, whose epic ends with the killing of a suppliant in a surge of rage, is its most troubling exemplar.

The father's *pietas* is likewise particular and likewise violent. He tells the boy that his job is to take care of him, that he was appointed by God to do so, and that he will kill anyone who touches him. He shoots the road-rat who seizes the boy; he fires the flare pistol into a window from which an archer has wounded him; he strips the thief who robbed them and leaves him naked on a cold beach. He refuses, almost without exception, every claim that strangers make on them, because every stranger threatens the one person for whom he lives. The limit of this ethic is that it is formally indistinguishable from the ethic of the bands it opposes. Every gang protects its own. "We are the good guys" is, as a sentence, available to anyone; the cannibals, too, may feed their children. *Pietas* alone cannot generate the distinction between the dyad and the bloodcults. It can only defend a distinction generated elsewhere.

The novel's treatment of the mother sharpens the Virgilian frame by inversion. In the flight from Troy, Aeneas loses his wife Creusa. When he returns into the burning city to search for her, her ghost appears and releases him, telling him not to grieve, prophesying his destiny, and charging him to keep their son's love (*Aen.* 2.771–789). Three times he tries to embrace her, and three times the image escapes his hands, like light winds or a fleeting dream (2.792–794). McCarthy's wife is lost before the flight begins, and by her own choice; her image returns to the man in dreams, and he learns to distrust them. Dreams of peril,

he concludes, are proper to a man in peril; dreams of comfort, and of her, are a summons toward languor and death. Where Creusa's ghost blesses the journey, the wife's memory tempts him to end it. He refuses her, and at last leaves her photograph lying on the road.

4.3 The Akedah Inverted: The Reserved Cartridge

The father's pistol holds two cartridges at the opening of the novel and, after the road-rat, one; and that last cartridge is reserved for the boy, to spare him capture, which in this world means rape, slaughter and being eaten. The father resolves to shoot the boy himself if they are taken; and in the flight from the cellar house, expecting to be found, he goes further, putting the pistol in the boy's hands and instructing him to shoot himself if the band finds him. The structure is the Akedah's. Abraham rises early, saddles his ass, takes his son, the wood, the fire and the knife, and walks for three days to the mountain where he is to sacrifice him (Gen. 22:1–10). Kierkegaard's pseudonym Johannes de Silentio distinguishes two movements Abraham might make (Kierkegaard 1983). The knight of infinite resignation gives up the beloved finite thing absolutely and reconciles himself to its loss; the knight of faith makes the further, absurd movement of believing that he will receive it back in this life, by virtue of the absurd, and so is able to act. The father of *The Road* is a knight of infinite resignation. He has rehearsed the killing of his son so often in imagination that he has in a sense already given him up, and the cartridge is the material token of that resignation. The flight from the cellar house radicalizes the structure: Abraham kept the knife in his own hand, whereas this father, for a moment, places it in Isaac's.

The decisive scene is his death. He does not take the boy with him. He tells the boy that he cannot do it, that he cannot hold his son dead in his arms, and that the boy must go on and carry the fire. This is the movement of faith, performed without the God who, for Kierkegaard, alone makes it possible. The father releases the son into a world he has every reason to believe damned, trusting by virtue of the absurd that the boy will be received back into goodness, not by the father but by the world. And the novel supplies the Akedah's substitute victim. In Genesis a ram caught in a thicket is offered in Isaac's stead (22:13). In *The Road* the father himself dies, and his death is what releases the son. Wilfred Owen's "The Parable of the Old Man and the Young" rewrote the Akedah for the generation of the Somme: the angel points to the ram, "But the old man would not so, but slew his son, / And half the seed of Europe, one by one" (Owen 1920). McCarthy writes the counter-parable. The old man takes the ram's place.

The comparative corpus of nuclear fiction shows how unusual this resolution is. In Nevil Shute's *On the Beach* (1957), the Australian government distributes suicide kits as the radiation approaches, and Peter Holmes must teach his wife how to end their infant daughter's life before the sickness reaches her; the novel ends with sanctioned, quiet deaths. In Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959), Abbot Zerchi sets himself

against the state's euthanasia camps for the irradiated and fails to prevent a mother from taking her doomed child there. Both novels make the mercy-killing of children an explicit moral question, and both resolve it in death. *The Road* raises the same question through its reserved cartridge and resolves it otherwise: the cartridge is never used on the boy.

4.4 The Wife's Argument

The novel's most rigorous philosophical position belongs to the character it dispatches earliest. In the flashback that records her last night, the wife argues that the man's protection is a delusion: that they will be caught, and she and the boy raped and murdered and eaten; that they are already the walking dead of a horror film; that she should have acted long ago; that her one hope is for eternal nothingness, which she hopes for with all her heart. She speaks of death in the language of a lover. Then she leaves the man and their son in the night and kills herself. Her position answers Camus's "one truly serious philosophical problem" in the negative (Camus 1955). It is not Camusian revolt, which persists in lucidity without appeal, but its refusal; nor, in her own self-understanding, is it despair. It is a calculation, consequentialist and probabilistic, of the expected suffering of a future she declines to enter. Revelation prophesies days in which men shall seek death and shall not find it (Rev. 9:6). The wife seeks it and finds it.

McCarthy published, in the same year as *The Road*, a dialogue that gives this position its fullest articulation. In *The Sunset Limited* (2006), a professor called White, pulled back from a suicide attempt on a subway platform by an evangelical ex-convict called Black, explains why he longs for darkness: the things he valued, culture and the life of the mind, have proved frail, and the world, in his image, is a labor camp from which innocent workers are led out by lottery each day to be executed. Black's faith does not refute him, and White leaves to complete what he began. Read together, the two texts of 2006 form a diptych in which the argument for annihilation receives its full intellectual dignity in one panel and is answered, in the other, not by an argument but by an existence.

That existence is the boy's. Hannah Arendt's concept of natality names what the wife's calculation omits: action, the human capacity to begin something new, is rooted in the fact of birth, and the miracle that saves the world from its normal, natural ruin is ultimately the birth of new human beings, so that the most glorious expression of hope for the world is the Gospel's announcement that a child has been born (Arendt 1958, §34). The boy, born after the end, is natality in its purest form, a beginning without a world to begin in. The wife's argument is not refuted; the novel never claims that her prediction was false. It is exceeded by a fact her calculus could not price.

Lee Edelman's polemic against reproductive futurism, the political fantasy that sacrifices every present to the figure of the Child as guarantor of the future (Edelman 2004), offers a sharper lens than criticism has yet applied. On its surface *The Road* is reproductive

futurism's apotheosis: the whole of value is invested in a child, and every act of the father is justified by the boy's future. But the boy himself refuses to be the Child. His ethics is not futural but radically present. He would give away their food to a starving old man today at the cost of their survival tomorrow; he would search for an abandoned child at the cost of the journey; he would return the thief's clothes at the cost of their safety. The father invests in the Child; the child invests in the stranger. The novel thereby splits Edelman's figure in two, and the split is its ethical engine.

4.5 Misericordia: The Ethics of the Stranger

The boy's ethics has its own classical name. *Misericordia*, the heart moved by another's misery, appears in the novel as a series of interventions that structure its episodes: the man burned by lightning whom the boy wants to help; the small boy glimpsed in a ruined town whom he wants to bring with them; Ely, whom he insists on feeding; the thief, whose nakedness he cannot bear. Each time the father refuses or resists, and each time the boy's distress reorganizes the scene. In the thief's case the father yields and walks back along the beach to leave the man's clothes and shoes where he might find them, though the thief does not reappear. The stripped man on the beach is Lear's "unaccommodated man," "a poor, bare, forked animal" (*King Lear* 3.4), and the boy's tears for him are the novel's version of Lear's prayer for the poor naked wretches who bide the pelting of the pitiless storm.

Schopenhauer's ethics of compassion offers the deepest account of what the boy is doing. In his essay on the basis of morality (Schopenhauer 1841), compassion, *Mitleid*, is the sole genuine moral incentive and the great mystery of ethics: the everyday phenomenon in which another's suffering moves me as though it were my own. His metaphysics explains the mystery. Compassion arises when the *principium individuationis*, the veil of Maya that makes beings appear separate, is seen through, and one recognizes in the other the same will that one is, *tat tvam asi*, "that art thou." The boy's relation to the other child he glimpses is a parable of this insight: he sees his double in a stranger and cannot rest until he knows the child is safe. The father remains inside the principle of individuation. For him there is the boy, and there is everyone else.

Levinas gives the same structure an account that dispenses with Schopenhauer's metaphysics of will. The face of the other, in its nakedness and destitution, resists my powers and commands me, before any choice of mine, not to kill; my responsibility for the other is infinite and asymmetrical, preceding all reciprocity (Levinas 1969). In *Otherwise than Being* (Levinas 1981) this responsibility becomes substitution: I am hostage to the other, answerable even for his responsibility. Levinas repeatedly cited, as the formula of this asymmetry, the words of the dying Markel in *The Brothers Karamazov*, that each of us is guilty before all and for all, and I more than the others (Levinas 1985). The boy's most important line is an

unconscious paraphrase of Markel. After the thief has been stripped, the father, trying to console him, says that the boy is not the one who has to worry about everything; the boy answers that he is, that he is the one. This is Cain's question, "Am I my brother's keeper?" (Gen. 4:9), answered for the first time in the affirmative. It is also Isaiah's prophecy that a little child shall lead them (Isa. 11:6), fulfilled in the most literal manner available to a story about walking.

Wagner, who read Schopenhauer obsessively, made the compassionate innocent the redeemer of his last music drama. Parsifal is the pure fool made wise through compassion, *durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*, who heals the wounded Grail king Amfortas. Behind Wagner stands Wolfram's *Parzival*, whose hero fails at his first visit to the Grail castle because he does not ask the suffering king what ails him, and succeeds at his second because he asks. Lydia Cooper has read *The Road* as a grail narrative (Cooper 2011), and this lineage sharpens the reading. The father is a wounded king, coughing blood, his land a waste; late in the novel he is shot in the leg with an arrow, the dolorous stroke of the Fisher King, whose wound in the thigh renders his kingdom barren (Weston 1920). The boy is the questioner, and his questions, whether they are still the good guys, whether they are going to die, whether the burned man can be helped, are the novel's versions of the healing question. That the king is not healed, and dies, measures how far the ash-world lies from the Grail castle. That waters flow in the coda, if only in memory, measures what the question nonetheless achieves.

Octavia Butler's *Parable of the Sower* (1993), the most important American road narrative of collapse besides McCarthy's, supplies the decisive comparison. Lauren Olamina walks north out of a burning Los Angeles along freeways haunted by scavengers and cannibals; she suffers from "hyperempathy," a neurological condition that makes her physically feel the pain she witnesses; and she founds a religion, Earthseed, whose axiom is that God is Change. Butler makes compassion a disability and gives it a doctrine and a community; McCarthy makes compassion a disposition and gives it neither. Butler's figure is a seed; McCarthy's is a fire. These are the two Stoic metaphors for the divine reason that survives the conflagration, the *logos spermatikos* and the *pyr technikon*, and the two great American road narratives of the end divide them between them.

4.6 The Bequest: Gun and Fire

The dialectic of *pietas* and *misericordia* is resolved not by the victory of either term but by a bequest. Dying, the father leaves the boy two things: the instruction to carry the fire, and the gun, which he tells him to keep. The novel refuses pacifism, and it does not launder the weapon: the gun the father bequeaths is the one whose last cartridge was meant for the boy, and which he once told the boy to turn on himself, so that the bequest converts an instrument of mercy-killing into an instrument of guardianship without erasing its first pur-

pose. The fire requires a guard, and the family that receives the boy at the end carries a shotgun. Here the Spartan origin of the pyrophore becomes exact. The fire-bearer marched within the army; he was inviolable, but not alone, and his inviolability was secured in practice by the spears around him. Pyrophoric ethics is in this sense guarded compassion: *misericordia* protected by *pietas*, the ethic of the stranger defended by the ethic of the line. The father's love was the condition of the boy's survival; the boy's love is the condition of the fire's meaning. At the father's death the two conditions pass into one person, and the boy becomes, for the first time, both.

V

CHAPTER FIVE

The Names of Things

Language After the Archive

As reference decays in The Road*, language does not fall silent; it descends through three strata, from naming to a phatic liturgy that sustains a relation, and from liturgy to images older than words, and the fire belongs to the deepest of them.*

5.1 The Entropy of Reference

The novel's most explicitly linguistic passage records the world's contraction toward a core of what can still be parsed, and the slow passage of names after their things into oblivion: the names of colors, of birds, of things to eat, and at last the names of things one believed to be true. A sacred vocabulary, the narration observes, has been severed from what it named, and so from reality itself. Ashley Kunsa has read this decay against the Adamic scene of naming (Gen. 2:19–20; Kunsa 2009), and the frame can be extended. Walter Benjamin's early essay "On Language as Such and on the Language of Man" (1916) distinguishes the Adamic name, in which language and thing correspond, from the fallen language of judgment and abstraction, and attributes to nature a deep sadness, a mourning that arises from its muteness and from being named by others (Benjamin 1996). The ash-world brings Benjamin's mourning to its limit. Nature is no longer merely mute; it is dead, and the names that once overnamed it now name nothing.

Augustine's semiotics clarifies the mechanism. A sign, he teaches, is a thing that brings something other than itself to mind, and things are learned through signs as signs are learned through things (*De doctrina christiana* I–II). In the *Confessions* he recalls learning

language by watching his elders point at objects while uttering their names (*Conf.* I.8). Wittgenstein opened the *Philosophical Investigations* by quoting this passage and dismantling its picture of language (Wittgenstein 1953, §1). The boy of *The Road* cannot learn language as Augustine did, because the objects are gone. He learns the names of birds he has never seen, of a soft drink he tastes once, of a sea he imagines as blue. His lexicon is a vocabulary of phantoms whose meanings are sustained only by the father's testimony. When the father dies, the guarantor of those meanings dies with him.

5.2 The Library and the Afterlife Conjecture

In one of the novel's few explicitly reflective scenes, the father stands in the burned ruins of a library among books swollen in standing water and feels a brief rage at the lies ranged by the thousand along its shelves. What surprises him is the discovery that the value of even the smallest thing had rested on a world to come, and that the very space such things occupied was itself an expectation. The passage anticipates by seven years Samuel Scheffler's "afterlife conjecture." In *Death and the Afterlife*, Scheffler argues that much of what we value depends on our confidence that human beings will survive us; drawing on P. D. James's *The Children of Men* (1992), in which universal infertility drains human projects of their point, he concludes that the collective afterlife matters to us, in some respects, more than our own survival (Scheffler 2013). The father's discovery is Scheffler's conjecture radicalized. Scheffler's thesis is axiological: value presupposes futurity. The father's is ontological: occupancy itself, the being-there of a book on a shelf, presupposes futurity.

Heidegger's analysis of equipment explains why (Heidegger 1927, §§15–18). Things are first encountered as ready-to-hand, embedded in a referential totality of in-order-to's that terminates in a for-the-sake-of-which, a possibility of human existence: the hammer is for nailing, nailing for building, building for shelter, and shelter for the sake of a human life that lies ahead. Remove the for-the-sake-of-which and the whole chain of references collapses; things drop from readiness-to-hand into mere presence-at-hand, objects without a world. The library is that collapse made visible. Its books are not destroyed so much as disclosed, at last, as things that had been held in being by an expectation that has failed.

Jacques Derrida argued in 1984 that literature is the genre most exposed to nuclear catastrophe, because it depends entirely on an archive it cannot ground, and that nuclear war is the hypothesis of a total and remainderless destruction of the archive, a referent literature can only anticipate (Derrida 1984). *The Road* depicts such a destruction and yet, as the Introduction observed, is itself composed of the archive it depicts destroyed. The comparative corpus shows the alternatives. Borges's "Library of Babel" (1941) is an infinite library whose books contain every combination of letters and therefore almost no meaning. Miller's *A Canticle for Leibowitz* imagines monks preserving the Memorabilia of a burned civilization through a new dark age, and venerating as a relic a scrap in their founder's

hand that proves to be a shopping list. Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* (1953) ends with fugitives who have memorized the burned books, each person become a volume. Each of these imaginations preserves, parodies or mourns a content. *The Road* preserves no content at all. Its archive is not carried; only the fire is.

5.3 The Storyteller's Death

Benjamin diagnosed a crisis in the transmission of experience. Men returned from the First World War not richer but poorer in communicable experience; a generation that had gone to school by horse-drawn tram now stood under the open sky in a landscape in which nothing remained unchanged but the clouds ("Experience and Poverty," 1933). The art of storytelling, which carries experience from mouth to mouth, was dying; and the storyteller's authority, he argued, had always been borrowed from death, which sanctions everything he can tell ("The Storyteller," 1936; Benjamin 1968). *The Road* stages both theses. The father tells the boy old stories of courage and justice; the boy eventually objects that the stories are not true, because in them people help others and they themselves help no one. The objection is the crisis of experience in its purest form. The stories transmit an experience in which ethics was livable; the boy's experience refutes it; and the father, whose experience can no longer be communicated, falls silent.

Jack London's *The Scarlet Plague* (1912) is the nearest earlier version of the scene. Sixty years after a pandemic, a ragged old man, once a professor of English, tells his half-wild grandsons about the world before; they mock his stories and his vocabulary, and he cannot make them understand what a university was, or money, or a city of millions. Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980) pushes the logic further, into a post-nuclear England whose language itself has degraded and whose central myth, the Eusa story, is a garbled memory of the splitting of the atom. Margaret Atwood's Snowman, in *Oryx and Crake* (2003), hoards rare words as talismans against oblivion while improvising a mythology for the engineered Crakers. McCarthy's strategy differs from all three. His characters' speech is stripped almost to nothing, but his narrator's is not. The narration preserves an archaic and technical lexicon, words such as *parsible*, *hydroptic* and *intestate*, in cadences modeled on the English Bible, and thereby performs in the act of narration the custodianship the father cannot. The style is the archive's last vault. Benjamin's second thesis is fulfilled by the novel's structure: the story the father cannot tell is told after his death, in the coda, by a voice whose authority is borrowed, quite literally, from his dying.

5.4 Style as Remnant: The Elohist Mode

Erich Auerbach opened *Mimesis* by contrasting two ways of telling. Homer's narrative, in the episode of Odysseus's scar, externalizes everything and leaves nothing in shadow; the

Elohist's narrative of the sacrifice of Isaac leaves nearly everything unexpressed, its time and place undefined, its thoughts and feelings unspoken, the whole "fraught with background" and demanding interpretation (Auerbach 1953, ch. 1). *The Road* is written in the Elohist mode, and its central ethical crisis is, as Chapter Four argued, an Akedah. The catastrophe is unnamed, the characters are unnamed, the geography is unnamed, the mother's decision is reported but not interpreted, and the dialogue, stripped of quotation marks and often of attribution, emerges from silence and returns to it. The prose advances by parataxis and polysyndeton, clause joined to clause by *and*, in a cadence that descends from the Hebrew narrative conjunction through the King James translators into English. Its typography enacts the ecology it describes: contractions lose their apostrophes, dialogue loses its marks, sentences lose their verbs, as though punctuation were among the goods that must be rationed.

José Saramago's *Blindness* (1995) offers the closest formal analogue. Its characters are likewise nameless (the doctor, the doctor's wife, the girl with dark glasses); its dialogue is likewise unmarked, run into the prose with commas and capitals; and its catastrophe, an epidemic of white blindness, likewise strips a society down to bare life, in a quarantine ruled by armed thugs. Both novels practice what may be called nominal ascesis, the withholding of proper names as the formal sign that the social order of names has collapsed. Saramago's narrator is ironic and digressive, McCarthy's incantatory and terse; both make the reader feel the absence of the name as the loss of a world.

Samuel Beckett is the third term. In *Endgame* (1957) the world beyond the window is, in Clov's report, gray from pole to pole; Hamm, blind and dying, depends on a servant he torments; and at the end Clov glimpses a small boy outside, whom Hamm imagines either dying out there or coming in. *The Road* takes the boy outside Beckett's window and makes him its protagonist. *The Unnamable* closes on an aporia of continuation, a voice that cannot go on and will go on; *Worstward Ho* (1983) distills an ethic of failure that tries again and fails better. The father's existence is that aporia, and the novel's prose is Beckett's lessness put to the service of a love story.

5.5 The Liturgy of "Okay"

Beneath the level of reference, the dyad's language persists as liturgy. Its most frequent word is "okay," exchanged in every register: as assent, as consolation, as a question about the other's condition, as the close of a dispute, as a promise. Bronisław Malinowski called "phatic communion" the use of language not to convey information but to create and sustain a bond (Malinowski 1923); J. L. Austin called "performative" the utterance that does what it says (Austin 1962). "Okay" in *The Road* is both. It conveys almost nothing and sustains everything. The repeated exchanges, a question answered by its own echo, have the antiphonal structure of versicle and response; the formulae "the good guys" and "carrying

the fire" function as a creed, a *symbolum*, recited to identify the faithful. Wittgenstein imagined a complete primitive language of four words, "block," "pillar," "slab," "beam," used by builders to coordinate their work, and remarked that to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life (Wittgenstein 1953, §§2, 19). The dyad's speech is such a builders' language: complete for its form of life, and its form of life is carrying.

Within this liturgy one figure stands apart, because it is the last living metaphor. Metaphor, for Aristotle, is the *epiphora*, the carrying-over, of a name; and Paul Ricoeur argued that the living metaphor, as opposed to the dead one absorbed into ordinary usage, retains the power to redescribe reality (Ricoeur 1977). In the ash-world every name is dying and every metaphor dead except one, and that one is the metaphor of carrying-over itself. "Carrying the fire" cannot be cashed out in literal terms; when the boy asks whether the fire is real, the father cannot point to it but only declare that he sees it. The phrase survives because it designates nothing except the act of transmission it performs. In a world without referents, language persists as pure *phora*.

5.6 Below Language: The Kekulé Problem

In 2017 McCarthy published in *Nautilus* his only extended essay, "The Kekulé Problem," on the relation between the unconscious and language (McCarthy 2017). Its occasion is August Kekulé's report that the ring structure of benzene came to him in a reverie of a snake seizing its own tail. McCarthy asks why the unconscious, which plainly solves problems, communicates in images and dreams rather than words, and proposes that it is an ancient biological system for running an animal, vastly older than language, to which language is a late, perhaps singular, and in evolutionary terms unaccustomed arrival. The essay is the best commentary on *The Road* its author wrote.

The novel is bracketed by two unconscious images. It opens with the father's dream of leading the boy, as though they were pilgrims in some old allegory, through the granite bowels of a cave to a black lake, where a pale and eyeless creature, translucent to its beating heart and its brain, lifts its head toward a scent it cannot see and lopes off into the dark. It closes with the trout. Between them the father lives by a rule about dreams: dreams of peril are proper to a man in peril, and dreams of comfort are the voice of death. The boy also dreams, of a wind-up toy penguin that comes around a corner though no one has wound it. The image is uncanny in the strict Freudian sense, and its theological charge is precise. The world's clocks stopped at 1:17, and the boy dreams of a mechanism that moves without a winder. William Paley's watchmaker argument inferred from the watch the existence of its maker (Paley 1802). The boy's nightmare is the watch without the watchmaker: a world that keeps moving after its maker has gone.

If language decays from naming to liturgy, the novel's deepest meanings lie beneath both, at the level McCarthy's essay assigns to the unconscious, the level of images. This is

why the fire cannot be explained, only seen, and why the novel's last word on the world comes not as a proposition but as a picture of fish.

VI

CHAPTER SIX

Carrying the Fire

A Genealogy of the Pyrophore

"Carrying the fire" condenses the principal Western technologies of transmitted fire into a single figure, and McCarthy's innovation is to strip it of every support those traditions supplied (altar, city, cosmos, covenant, archive) until nothing remains but the carrying.

6.1 The Bearers

Greek forms its bearers with *-phoros*. The *pyrphoros* bears fire; the *phosphoros* bears light, and that name, Latinized as Lucifer, belongs to the morning star and, through Isaiah's taunt against the king of Babylon (Isa. 14:12), to the fallen angel. The *Christophoros* bears Christ. In the legend collected by Jacobus de Voragine in the *Golden Legend* (c. 1260), the giant Reprobus, seeking the mightiest master, sets himself to carry travelers across a dangerous river; one night he bears a child who grows so heavy in midstream that the giant fears they will drown, and the child reveals that he has carried not only the whole world but its maker. The man of *The Road* is a Christopher: he carries his son on his back across streams and over ruin, and the son is, by the father's conditional, the word of God, a weight heavier than the world. The boy is the pyrophore. The novel distributes the two bearers between its protagonists.

The demonic double of both is Lucifer, the light-bearer who falls, whom Romantic Satanism fused with Prometheus, the thief of fire. On most readings the novel's catastrophe is itself a Promethean fire, a technological light brighter than the sun. The pyro-

phore's fire is its antithesis, and the genealogy that follows is the history of how that antithesis was assembled.

6.2 Stolen Fire: Prometheus and Pandora

In Hesiod, Zeus hides fire from men, and Prometheus steals it back concealed in a hollow fennel stalk (*WD* 50–52; *Theog.* 565–567). The first fire-bearer of Greek myth is thus a thief who carries fire in a vessel. Aeschylus's Prometheus boasts that the fire he gave is the teacher of every art for mortals and their great resource; he adds that he gave them a second gift, blind hopes, which he planted in them so that they would cease to foresee their deaths (*PV* 107–111, 248–252). Fire and hope arrive together, as they do in *The Road*. Hesiod's Pandora completes the pattern. When she lifts the lid of the jar, every evil flies out to wander the earth; only Hope, Elpis, stays within, beneath the rim (*WD* 90–99). Whether Elpis is a good preserved for men or an evil withheld from them has divided interpreters since antiquity.

The Road inherits the ambiguity whole. The boy is a vessel, imaged as a golden chalice, in whom something remains after every evil has been released into the world, and the father insists that it is inside him; the wife regards his hope as a delusion; the novel never adjudicates. What it does is relocate Prometheus. The stolen fire, the fire of *technē*, is the fire that on the novel's most probable etiology ended the world. McCarthy's last novels make the connection explicit. In *The Passenger* (2022), the father of Bobby and Alicia Western was a physicist on the Manhattan Project, and his children's lives unfold in the shadow of his work. Oppenheimer recalled that at the Trinity test a line of the *Bhagavad Gita* came to him: now I am become Death, the destroyer of worlds (*Gita* 11.32). The Promethean fire returns as the radiance of a thousand suns. The pyrophore's fire is the other fire, given rather than stolen, kept rather than unleashed.

6.3 Kept Fire: Vesta and the Flight from Troy

Against the stolen fire stands the kept fire of the hearth. Hestia, eldest of the Olympians, was the fire at the center of every household and every city; at Rome, as Vesta, her flame burned perpetually in the round temple in the Forum, tended by virgins whose failure to keep it alight was punished as a portent of public disaster. The *Aeneid* makes this fire the substance of translation. On the night Troy falls, the ghost of Hector entrusts to Aeneas the city's sacred objects and its household gods, and brings forth from the inmost shrine the fillets, mighty Vesta, and the eternal fire, *aeternumque adytis effert penetralibus ignem* (*Aen.* 2.293–297). Rome will be founded so that this fire may have a hearth.

Two further moments of the flight bear directly on *The Road*. While Anchises still refuses to leave, a light tongue of flame appears on the crown of the small Iulus's head, lick-

ing his soft hair without harm and feeding about his temples (*Aen.* 2.682–684); his parents rush to quench it, but Anchises reads it as a sign, and a falling star confirms it. The child crowned with harmless fire is the boy of *The Road*, whom the father, watching him by firelight, sees as a golden vessel fit to house a god. And the image with which the flight begins, father on the shoulders and son by the hand, has already been read in Chapter Four as the iconographic source of the novel's dyad.

Virgil's other prophecy of a child completes the pattern. The Fourth Eclogue announces that the last age of the Sibyl's song has come, that the great order of the ages is born anew, *magnus ab integro saeclorum nascitur ordo*, that the Virgin returns and a new progeny descends from heaven, and that with the birth of a boy the iron race will cease and a golden one arise (*Ecl.* 4.4–10). Christian readers took the poem for a prophecy of Christ. The boy of *The Road* is the Eclogue's *puer* born into the wrong age. His birth inaugurates no golden race; the iron age does not end with him but before him, in ash. He is the new progeny of a world with no order of ages left to renew.

6.4 Sacred Fire: The Spartan Pyrphoros

The Spartan fire-bearer with whom the Introduction began contributes the decisive structural element: the fire is carried between two altars. It is taken from the sacrifice to Zeus the Leader at home and borne to the frontier, where it kindles the next sacrifice; between the two it marches with the army, carried by a man whom, by convention, the enemy will not kill (*Lac.* 13.2–3). The fire's meaning is its continuity, the thread binding the army in the field to the city it has left and the gods it serves. *The Road* preserves the bearer and the march and deletes both altars. Father and son visit the house in which the father grew up and leave it; there is no hearth behind them. They reach the sea and find nothing; there is no frontier sacrifice ahead. The fire has no origin to which it is faithful and no destination it will kindle. It is carried between nowhere and nowhere, and its whole meaning is the carrying.

6.5 Scriptural Fire: Pillar, Bush, Altar, Tongues

The Bible supplies five fires the novel absorbs. The pillar of fire leads Israel through the wilderness by night (Exod. 13:21), as the boy's fire leads the dyad through a darkness that has lasted years. The bush burns and is not consumed (Exod. 3:2), as the fire in the boy burns without consuming him, in pointed contrast to the fire that consumed the world. The altar fire "shall ever be burning upon the altar; it shall never go out" (Lev. 6:13), the injunction the father in effect lays upon his son. The Gospel of John names the Word as the light that shines in darkness and "lighteth every man that cometh into the world" (John 1:9), the theological ground of the father's claim that the fire is inside the boy and always

has been; the claim also echoes the Quaker doctrine of the inner light, George Fox's "that of God in every one" (Fox 1952), which the father, uniquely, claims he can see.

The fifth fire is Pentecost. When the Spirit descends upon the apostles there comes a sound from heaven "as of a rushing mighty wind," and there appear "cloven tongues like as of fire," which sit upon each of them, and they speak so that every listener hears in his own language (Acts 2:1–6). Pentecost is the canonical reversal of Babel: language scattered and confounded is restored by wind and fire. *The Road* is a novel of Babel in its most extreme form, a world in which names are dying altogether. At its end, as Chapter Seven shows, the boy carries the fire and a woman speaks to him of the breath of God. Fire and breath are the two signs of Pentecost. The novel ends among the elements of a language's renewal, without promising that the renewal will occur.

6.6 Mystical Fire: Luria and Böhme

Lurianic Kabbalah, as Chapter Two observed, imagines the divine light scattered as sparks among the shells of a shattered creation, awaiting human gathering. Jakob Böhme's theosophy, which McCarthy knew well enough to take from it an epigraph for *Blood Meridian*, offers a more dynamic account of fire. For Böhme the divine life unfolds from an unground (*Ungrund*) through seven source-spirits, and at the turning point between the dark world and the light world stands fire: a dark fire of wrath and anguish that, through a kind of death and breakthrough, becomes the light fire of love (Böhme 1623; Koyré 1929). The wrath-fire is not abolished in the love-fire; it is its ground and condition. Böhme's doctrine of signatures holds, further, that all things bear on their surfaces the marks of their inner essence (Böhme 1622).

The relevance to McCarthy's oeuvre is structural. The Böhme epigraph of *Blood Meridian* speaks of the life of darkness as a life without sorrow, sorrow being swallowed up in death; that novel's world is Böhme's wrath-fire, presided over by Judge Holden, for whom war is god. *The Road* passes through the same fire and finds on its far side the love-fire, carried by a child. And the coda, as Chapter Seven argues, is written in Böhme's script of signatures.

6.7 Sacramental and Industrial Fire: Hopkins and Melville

Gerard Manley Hopkins wrote the most exact poetic theology of the fire McCarthy imagines. "As kingfishers catch fire, dragonflies draw flame," the sonnet begins, and it argues that each mortal thing deals out the being that dwells within it; that "the just man justices," enacting his justice rather than possessing it; and that "Christ plays in ten thousand places, / Lovely in limbs, and lovely in eyes not his / To the Father through the features of men's faces" (Hopkins 1918). The boy holds no doctrine of goodness; he justices. And the father, who sees the fire inside him, sees the divine through the features of a face.

"God's Grandeur" declares that the world is charged with God's grandeur and "will flame out, like shining from shook foil"; that generations have trod till all is "seared with trade"; and that nevertheless "nature is never spent; / There lives the dearest freshness deep down things," because the Holy Ghost broods over the bent world "with warm breast and with ah! bright wings." The seared world, the flame, the freshness deep down things and the brooding Spirit are, in that order, the ash-world, the boy's fire, the coda's deep glens and the woman's breath of God.

Melville supplies the industrial counter-image. In "The Try-Works" (*Moby-Dick*, ch. 96), Ishmael, steering at night by the furnaces in which whale blubber is boiled into oil, falls into a reverie and nearly capsizes the ship; he warns the reader, "Look not too long in the face of the fire, O man!," lest it invert and deaden him. The try-works is a factory in which bodies are rendered into light for the lamps of the world: the industrial ancestor of the cellar, a fire that consumes bodies to produce energy. Melville's warning is the pyrophore's discipline. The father and son tend a fire that warms and does not render, and the novel's moral topography is the distinction between the two.

6.8 McCarthy's Own Fire

Within McCarthy's oeuvre the fire has a history of its own, which this study proposes to call a pyrogenesis in four stages. The epilogue of *Blood Meridian* (1985) shows a man at dawn progressing across a plain by means of holes he makes in the ground, striking with his implement the fire out of the rock that God has put there, while wanderers behind him search for bones; the image has been read as the fencing of the West, the Promethean enclosure of the earth. Here fire is struck, extracted from matter by technique. The closing pages of *No Country for Old Men* (2005) record Sheriff Bell's dream of his dead father riding past him at night through a mountain pass, carrying fire in a horn as men once did, going on ahead to kindle a fire somewhere in the cold and dark, where Bell knows he will find him waiting. Here fire is carried by the dead, ahead, as the ancestral promise of a camp beyond death. In *The Road* (2006) the fire migrates from the horn into the child: no longer carried in an external vessel by a dead father ahead, but carried within a living son, onward. And in *The Passenger* (2022) McCarthy confesses the fire's other origin, in the bomb on which a father worked.

The sequence also redistributes the Aenean triad across two novels. Bell's father, who goes ahead into the dark with the fire, is Anchises, the ancestor; the man of *The Road* is Aeneas; the boy is Iulus. In McCarthy's late work the flight from Troy takes two books to complete, and its order is reversed: Anchises goes first, carrying the fire into death; Aeneas follows, carrying the child; and the child goes on alone, carrying the fire within him.

6.9 Against Content: Faulkner's Voice and Bradbury's Books

William Faulkner accepted the Nobel Prize in December 1950 with a speech composed under the shadow of the bomb. The tragedy of the age, he said, was a physical fear so long sustained that problems of the spirit had given way to the single question of when one would be blown up. He refused to accept the end of man; he imagined the last stroke of doom fading from a final barren rock in a dying red evening, and even then one more sound, man's "puny inexhaustible voice," still talking; he named the old verities the writer must not forget, love and honor and pity and pride and compassion and sacrifice; and he concluded that man would not merely endure but prevail (Faulkner 1950). Albert Erskine, Faulkner's editor at Random House, was also McCarthy's, from *The Orchard Keeper* onward. *The Road* reads as the trial of Faulkner's speech. Its rock is barren, its evening red and dying, its last voice a boy's, still talking to his dead father. Compassion and sacrifice are its plot. But it withholds Faulkner's final verb. Man does not prevail in *The Road*; he does not even clearly endure. He carries.

The difference between Faulkner's verities and McCarthy's fire is the difference between content and transmission. Faulkner names what the voice will say; McCarthy names only that something is passed on. Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* makes the same contrast from the other side. Its book-people, walking along the railroad tracks away from a city destroyed by war, carry the burned library in their memories, each a living volume; the novel ends with Granger's parable of the phoenix and with Montag's discovery that fire, which he had known only as the destroyer of books, can also warm. Bradbury's carriers carry contents. McCarthy's carry none. The fire of *The Road* is not a memorized archive but the disposition that would make any archive worth carrying. That is the novel's subtraction, and its boldness.

6.10 The Subtraction

Source	Fire	Vessel	Telos	What The Road subtracts
Heraclitus; the Stoa	Ever-living, designing fire	The cosmos	Rebirth of an identical world	Measure and regeneration
Hesiod; Aeschylus	Stolen fire, with blind hopes	Hollow fennel stalk	The arts of mortals	The theft: the fire is given, not stolen
Hesiod (Pandora)	Hope (Elpis)	The jar	Kept within	Nothing: the boy is the vessel in which it remains
Xenophon; Herodotus	Sacrificial fire	The fire-bearer's hands	The frontier sacrifice	Both altars
Virgil	Vesta's eternal fire	Hearth and household gods	Rome	City and empire
Exodus; Leviticus	Pillar; perpetual altar fire	The tabernacle	The promised land	Covenant and land

Source	Fire	Vessel	Telos	What The Road subtracts
Acts 2	Tongues of fire, with wind	The apostles	Language restored	The promise (fire and breath remain)
Luria	Scattered sparks	Shattered vessels	Tikkun	Cosmic redemption
Böhme	Love-fire born of wrath-fire	The soul	The light-world	The theosophical system
Bradbury	Memorized books	Human memory	The rebuilt city	Content
No Country for Old Men	Fire in a horn	The horn	A camp beyond death	The external vessel
The Road	**The fire inside**	**The child**	**None given**	**Origin and destination: transmission alone**

Read down its final column, the table records a systematic subtraction. Every tradition the novel inherits supplied its fire with a source, a vessel distinct from the bearer, a destination and a content. McCarthy removes all four. What remains is a fire whose source is the bearer, whose vessel is the bearer, whose destination is the next bearer, and whose content is its own transmission. This is the pyrophore in the full double sense the Introduction proposed: carried, and self-igniting.

VII

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Coast and the Coda

The Testament of the Intestate Earth

The novel's ending executes two testaments, the father's spoken will to his son and the earth's written will to the reader, and thereby transforms the post-apocalyptic narrative into a work of probate.

7.1 Thalatta Without Rescue

Xenophon records that when the Ten Thousand, retreating through the mountains of Anatolia, at last sighted the sea from the summit of Mount Theches, the vanguard raised the shout *Thalatta! Thalatta!*, the sea, the sea; the soldiers wept and embraced their officers, for the sea meant the road home (*Anab.* 4.7.21–26). The arrival at the sea is one of the oldest figures of deliverance in Western narrative, and *The Road* reverses it. The boy, who has imagined the sea as blue, finds it gray, cold and dead under a sky of ash; nothing lies on the other side; no one is waiting. The arrival is an anti-*Thalatta*. It also recalls the beaches of the nuclear imagination: Shute's characters await death on an Australian shore, and Wells's Traveller watches the earth's last life on a terminal one. McCarthy's beach is a place neither of rescue nor quite of ending, but of passage.

Two objects on that coast condense the novel's theology of signals. The first is a sailboat lying offshore, its name painted in Spanish, *Pájaro de Esperanza*, Bird of Hope, its home port in the Canary Islands. The father swims out to it and returns with provisions. The bird of hope is Noah's dove, sent from the ark to learn whether the waters had abated, which returns the second time with an olive leaf in its mouth and the third time returns no more (Gen. 8:8–12). McCarthy's dove yields tins and a flare pistol, and no leaf. Aboard it the father also finds a sextant, an instrument for navigating by the stars, under a sky in which no

star has been visible for years. The second object is the flare itself. The father fires it over the water at night, and the boy wonders whether anyone could have seen it. It is a fire sent up to no known recipient: the signal fire of *Lord of the Flies*, which summoned a rescuer, emptied of any rescuer to summon; Pascal's silence of infinite spaces, addressed nonetheless.

7.2 The Father's Testament

The father's death is the novel's nuncupative will, the oral testament the law permitted to soldiers in service and mariners at sea, persons *in extremis* without leisure for writing. He tells the boy to go on without him, to keep the gun, and to carry the fire. When the boy asks whether the fire is real, and where it is, the father answers that it is inside him and always was, and that he can see it. He tells the boy that he cannot take him with him, that he cannot hold his son dead in his arms. He tells him that he may talk to his father, and that his father will talk to him. The testament bequeaths a weapon, a fire and the promise of continued speech.

Its literary form is Dante's. At the summit of the mountain of Purgatory, as Beatrice appears, the pilgrim turns to Virgil and finds him gone: "Virgilio dolcissimo patre," Virgil, sweetest father, to whom he had given himself for his salvation (*Purg.* 30.49–51). The pagan guide who has led the pilgrim through hell and up the mountain cannot enter the earthly paradise; he vanishes at its threshold, and another guide, a woman, takes his place. The man of *The Road* is Virgil. He has led the boy through an inferno and down the long road south, and he dies at the threshold of whatever lies beyond. The woman who will speak to the boy of God is his Beatrice. Dante's three canticles all end on the same word, *stelle*, the stars. McCarthy's sky has no stars, and his novel ends on another word.

The boy stays beside his father's body for three days. The interval is the *triduum*, the three days between crucifixion and resurrection, and Shelly Rambo's theology of remaining, which reads the Holy Saturday between death and life as the space that trauma inhabits (Rambo 2010), describes its texture exactly. But the novel transfers the resurrection from the dead to the living. The father does not rise; the son does, and walks out to the road. Byron's "Darkness" had imagined the same vigil. Amid the universal famine one dog "was faithful to a corse," keeping birds, beasts and starving men at bay, seeking no food, licking the hand that answered with no caress, until it died. The vigil that ends in death is the proverb's, and Byron's. The vigil that ends in departure is the pyrophore's.

7.3 The Rachel

After the third day a man comes down the road, armed with a shotgun, and tells the boy that he and his family have been following the pair; he invites the boy to come with them.

The boy asks the questions that matter: whether the man is one of the good guys, whether he is carrying the fire, whether he eats people. The man answers in the dyad's own liturgy. The father's body is wrapped in a blanket and left in the woods. The family consists of a woman, a boy and a girl.

This last scene of adoption completes an arc that began with the novel's most terrible image. Jeremiah hears a voice in Ramah, lamentation and bitter weeping, "Rahel weeping for her children refused to be comforted for her children, because they were not" (Jer. 31:15), and Matthew applies the verse to Herod's massacre of the innocents (Matt. 2:18). The spitted newborn of *The Road* belongs to Rachel's lament. McCarthy's favorite novel, *Moby-Dick*, ends with the same matriarch. Ishmael, sole survivor of the *Pequod*, floats on Queequeg's coffin until he is picked up by "the devious-cruising Rachel, that in her retracing search after her missing children, only found another orphan" (Melville 1851, Epilogue). The *Rachel* had lost its captain's son in pursuit of the white whale and was searching for him when it found Ishmael. *The Road* ends as *Moby-Dick* ends: an orphan is gathered in by searchers who had been seeking their own. The family that adopts the boy is the *Rachel*.

The adoption is a hospitality conditioned on recognition. Derrida distinguishes unconditional hospitality, which welcomes the arrivant without asking a name, from the conditional hospitality of law, which asks who comes (Derrida 2000). The boy and the stranger test one another, and their mutual testing is the conditional hospitality that makes unconditional welcome survivable. The family is a minimal *ekklesia*, a community of the called-out, constituted not by doctrine but by mutual recognition of the fire.

7.4 From Logos to Pneuma

The last paragraph of narrative proper, before the coda, gives the novel's final theological statement, and gives it to the woman. She would sometimes speak to the boy about God. When he tried to pray he found it better to speak to his father instead, and he did so, and he did not forget him. The woman told him that this was all right, and that God's breath was still his breath, passed from one person to the next through all of time.

The statement completes a transformation that runs through the whole novel. The father's theology was a theology of the Word: the boy as *logos*, God's speech, the sole remaining instance of divine utterance. The woman's is a theology of the Breath, *ruach*, *pneuma*, *spiritus*: the breath God blew into the nostrils of the first man so that he became a living soul (Gen. 2:7), passing now from human being to human being through time. Qoheleth called all things *hevel*, breath or vapor, vanity of vanities; the woman inverts him. Breath is not vanity but continuity, the divine itself as what is passed on. Martin Buber's claim that every particular Thou is a glimpse through to the eternal Thou (Buber 1970) authorizes the boy's choice: to speak to his father is to address, through him, whatever the

divine still is. The movement from Logos to Pneuma is also a movement from a masculine to a feminine voice. The novel that began with a mother's refusal ends with a woman's affirmation, and its patrilineal transmission is framed between the two.

A final convergence returns the argument to Chapter One. For the Stoics, the soul of the world and of every living being was *pneuma*, a blend of fire and air, the warm breath that holds the cosmos together; in the *ekpyrosis* the cosmos dissolves into fire, and in the *palingenesia pneuma* reconstitutes it. *The Road* ends with fire, carried by a boy, and with air, breath, spoken of by a woman. The Stoic *pneuma*, substance of a world's rebirth, has been recomposed out of a child's fire and a woman's breath. The regeneration that the cosmos no longer guarantees is enacted, in miniature and without guarantee, by a household.

7.5 The Coda: Vermiculate Writing

Then the novel closes with a paragraph that belongs to no character. It recalls, in the past tense of fable, that brook trout once lived in the mountain streams, visible as they held their place in the amber water, fins edged in white and stirring in the current, smelling of moss when held; that their backs bore vermiculate patterns that were "maps of the world in its becoming," maps and labyrinths of something that could be neither restored nor repaired; and that in the deep hollows they inhabited everything was older than humankind and gave off a hum of mystery.

Four formal features govern its interpretation. The first is tense: the coda opens with the formula of fable, *once*, answering the father's opening dream of pilgrims in an allegory, so that the novel is bracketed by the registers of the dreamed and the told. The second is person: the coda addresses the reader directly, in the second person, for the first and only time in the novel. The third is its narrator. The father is dead, and the boy has never seen a trout; the image belongs, earlier in the novel, to the father's memory of trout turning in a deep pool, flashing in the dark water like blades in a cave. The coda is the father's memory surviving the father: a memory without a rememberer, executed after his death like a will. The fourth is symmetry. The novel begins with a blind, translucent creature in a cave, its viscera exposed, mapless and sightless, and ends with a creature whose surface bears maps. Between the two, the world passes from blindness to legibility, from the interior of the beast to the inscribed surface of the fish, from a dream to a testimony.

The adjective *vermiculate*, worm-tracked, carries the book's whole genealogy. *Vermis* is the worm of decay and of the grave; vermiculation is also the worm-track cut as ornament into rusticated stone, and the trail of the bookworm through the pages of an old volume. The burned library of Chapter Five is replaced by another book, the Book of Nature, which Augustine, Hugh of St. Victor and Galileo read beside Scripture, and whose characters, for Galileo, were triangles and circles (Galilei 1623). McCarthy's characters are vermiculations and mazes. They are Böhme's signatures, the marks by which a creature's inner essence is

written on its surface (Böhme 1622). They are, in Derrida's terms, an arche-writing, a trace prior to speech (Derrida 1976). And they are Hopkins's. "Pied Beauty" gives glory to God for dappled things, "For rose-moles all in stipple upon trout that swim," and ends: "He fathers-forth whose beauty is past change: / Praise him" (Hopkins 1918). The coda is Hopkins's poem with the doxology withheld. In place of *Praise him*, McCarthy writes *mystery*.

"In its becoming" locates the maps in time. Darwin closed the *Origin of Species* with life's "endless forms most beautiful and most wonderful" that "have been, and are being, evolved" (Darwin 1859). Spinoza distinguished *natura naturata*, nature as produced, from *natura naturans*, nature as producing (*Ethics* I, P29 schol.). Ernst Bloch built an ontology of the Not-Yet, a world still in process toward a homeland in which no one has yet been (Bloch 1986). Whitehead's metaphysics of process holds that the many become one and are increased by one (Whitehead 1929). The trout bear on their backs the cartography of an unfinished world. The ash-world is *natura naturata*, nature produced and then destroyed; the coda remembers *natura naturans*.

7.6 Irreversibility, Deep Time, Mystery

The coda's negative clauses, that what the maps record can be neither restored nor repaired, name the irreversibility that is the novel's deepest temporal truth. Physically, it is the second law of thermodynamics, Clausius's principle that the entropy of the world tends toward a maximum (Clausius 1865), the arrow along which no burned forest reassembles. Morally, it is the irreparable. Vladimir Jankélévitch distinguished the irreversible, the fact that time cannot be run backward, from what it nonetheless guarantees: that whoever has been can never thereafter not have been, and that this mysterious and profoundly obscure fact of having been is a viaticum for eternity (Jankélévitch 1974). *Viaticum*, provision for the road, is also the name of the Eucharist given to the dying. The coda is the viaticum of *The Road*: the provision for the journey, given at the journey's end, which consists in the indestructible having-been of the world. The trout are gone, and nothing can make them not have been.

"Older than man" locates the maps in deep time. James Hutton, reading the rocks of Scotland, concluded that he found "no vestige of a beginning,—no prospect of an end" (Hutton 1788). Within the time of the trout, the catastrophe of *The Road* is an episode, like the impact that ended the Cretaceous. Robinson Jeffers's inhumanism asked readers to decenter the human in their regard for the world and to trust that the beauty of things would outlast human defacement of the earth (Jeffers 1954); Timothy Morton has argued that the world, as the stable background of human meaning, has already ended (Morton 2013). The coda is inhumanist in this precise sense: it locates value in what precedes and exceeds the human. But it is not misanthropic. It is addressed to a "you."

The last word is *mystery*. Gabriel Marcel distinguished a problem, which I meet as lying wholly before me and can survey from outside, from a mystery, in which I am myself involved, so that the distinction between what is in me and what is before me loses its meaning (Marcel 1948). The novel's opening questions were problems: what happened, how to survive, where to go. Its last word converts them into a mystery that involves its reader. And the word recalls the one Schopenhauer had chosen for compassion, the great mystery of ethics. The novel ends by displacing the mystery of the boy's compassion onto the world itself, as though the hum in the deep hollows and the fire in the child were one phenomenon heard at two scales. The mystery is not solved. It is bequeathed.

7.7 The Testament

The chapter's argument can now be gathered. The earth of *The Road* dies, in the novel's own word, intestate. At law an intestate estate passes to heirs by default rules; where there are no heirs, it escheats to the sovereign. The ash-world has no sovereign left to receive it, and its estate would escheat to no one were it not for the coda, which is the testament the earth was said to lack. It is holographic, written wholly in the testator's own hand, the vermiculations being the earth's own script. Its legacy is the having-been of a world in its becoming. Its legatee is named in the only way a testament in such a script could name one: by address. The coda's second person designates the one figure in the novel's universe who stands outside the catastrophe, the reader.

The two testaments are therefore symmetrical. The father's is spoken, made *in extremis*, and bequeaths a fire to a son; the earth's is written, made after the end, and bequeaths a mystery to a reader. The novel's dedication, to John Francis McCarthy, the author's son, born when his father was in his mid-sixties, makes the whole book a third testament, a father's to a son, written in the knowledge that the father might not live to see the son grown. Publication extends the bequest. Every reader is adopted into the line of the fire, as the boy is adopted by the family that has been following him. *The Road* is not finally a post-apocalyptic narrative but a work of probate, and reading it is the act by which its estate passes.

CONCLUSION

Pyrophoria

An Ethics for the After

The Road founds an ethics that survives the end of the world because it never depended on the world. That ethics, pyrophoria, can now be stated in six theses.

The first is the thesis of non-totality. An apocalypse in which the fire-bearer survives is not total, and *The Road* is constructed so that its apocalypse cannot be. Byron's "Darkness" fulfills the Greek proverb; McCarthy's novel negates it. The question the novel asks is therefore not why the world ended, which it declines, nor whether its protagonists survive, which it suspends, but what is carried.

The second is the thesis of contentlessness. The fire has no propositional content. It cannot be stated, only transmitted; it is the metaphor of metaphor, the last living figure in a language of dead names, and it survives the death of reference because it never depended on reference. Where Faulkner names the verities and Bradbury memorizes the books, McCarthy names only the carrying.

The third is the thesis of double ignition. The fire is carried, as the Spartan fire-bearer carried the altar fire and Aeneas carried Vesta's, and it is self-igniting, as a pyrophoric substance ignites in air. Goodness in the novel is neither nature nor nurture but an ignition-relation, which catches only on contact with another. The boy's pity is lit by the father's stories and exceeds them on contact with faces the stories never described.

The fourth is the thesis of horizontal transcendence. Under a closed sky the absolute changes axis. The father stakes the whole history of divine speech on a single child, and the child spends that stake on strangers. Theology becomes care and prayer becomes attention; the God of the ash-world, if there is one, is Jonas's God who has given himself away and Whitehead's fellow-sufferer, and the only direction in which a gift to him can travel is toward another human being.

The fifth is the thesis of the guarded fire. Pyrophoria is not pacifism. The fire-bearer marches inside the army, and the boy inherits both the fire and the gun, a gun first meant for his own death. The ethic of the stranger survives only under the protection of the ethic of the line: *misericordia* without *pietas* dies on the road, and *pietas* without *misericordia* becomes indistinguishable from the bands it fights.

The sixth is the thesis of testamentary address. The novel executes two testaments, the father's spoken will and the earth's written one, and names as legatee of the second the reader whom the coda addresses. Literature becomes the probate of an intestate world, and reading becomes the act by which a fire passes.

These theses position *The Road* against its principal interlocutors with some precision. Against Hobbes, the dyad rests on a covenant of carrying rather than of fear, and its subject corrects its sovereign. Against Nietzsche, the self-made god of the ash-world is the cannibal, and the figure who surpasses the human is a child. Against Jonas's imperative, which enjoins us to act so that genuine human life may persist, pyrophoria is an ethics *for the after*: it does not presuppose that the world will be saved, and so cannot be refuted by the world's loss. Against Edelman, the Child of reproductive futurism is split into a father's investment and a child's present obligation. Against Butler, the fire has no doctrine. Against Faulkner, it does not prevail; it carries.

The reading has limits that should be stated plainly. The transmission it describes is patrilineal, and the novel's women, the mother who refuses and the woman who adopts, frame rather than conduct it; the final turn from Logos to Pneuma mitigates this asymmetry without dissolving it. The dyad's unmarked universality, a nameless man and a nameless boy offered as everyman, abstracts from the racial, gendered and economic differences that, as *Parable of the Sower* insists, determine who survives a collapse and how. And the guarded fire depends on a violence the novel never repudiates. A pyrophoric ethics must carry these questions too.

What it offers in return is an account of moral persistence suited to an age that has begun to speak of the end of the world as a condition rather than an event. In the Anthropocene, the world's end is less a future that heroic action might still avert than a present that must be inhabited: species gone, coastlines lost, irreversibilities accumulating. An ethics adequate to such a present cannot depend on restoration, because the coda's verdict is that some things cannot be restored. It can depend only on what *The Road* depends on: that something can still be handed on, and that the handing-on is itself the good.

The Greeks said of a total defeat that not even the fire-bearer was left. *The Road* tells of a world of which everything else can be said, and of which that cannot. Its last word is *mystery* because a mystery is what remains when the fire-bearer survives: not knowledge, not salvation, not a world restored, but an involvement; a having-been that cannot be undone;

a becoming that is not yet over. The fire-bearer was left. In the novel, it is a boy. After the novel, it is whoever has finished reading it.

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Cormac McCarthy · *The Road* · pyrophoria · fire-bearer · post-apocalyptic fiction · testamentary fiction · remnant theology · apocalypse · ekpyrosis · Stoicism · Heraclitus · Prometheus · Vesta · *Aeneid* · Akedah · Kierkegaard · theodicy · death of God · Nietzsche · Hans Jonas · Emmanuel Levinas · Arthur Schopenhauer · compassion · *pietas* · *misericordia* · natality · Hannah Arendt · Walter Benjamin · Jacques Derrida · Giorgio Agamben · Martin Heidegger · *Gestell* · Thomas Hobbes · Jean-Jacques Rousseau · state of nature · cannibalism · René Girard · Northrop Frye · archive · language and reference · the Kekulé problem · Anthropocene · ecocriticism · nuclear criticism · Byron's "Darkness" · *Moby-Dick* · Gerard Manley Hopkins · William Faulkner · Octavia Butler · speculative fiction · philosophy and literature · American literature



The fire-bearer was left.

ὁ πυρφόρος ἐλείφθη